



Argentina bids Messi farewell

Argentina is confronting a once-unimaginable reality: a national team without soccer great Lionel Messi. The 39-year-old Messi bid farewell to international soccer after 21 years, 126 goals, two Copa America titles and a World Cup championship.

P6

THE Hans India



Mahima Nambiar calls 'Comrade Kalyan' a fun entertainer

Actress Mahima Nambiar has joined hands with Sree Vishnu for the first time in Telugu film 'Comrade Kalyan' which is a period entertainer laced with humor, romance and drama. The actress said she enjoys the role of comic relief in Sree Vishnu's style.

P8

'Seva aur Nishta', CRPF leads from the front

October 1 marks historical milestones for the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF), including operational sacrifices and administrative landmarks. Every year, since 1969, on 1 October, the Force pays solemn tribute to Constable G D Govind Singh.

P4

RBI fires first rate-hike salvo in 4 yrs, repo at 5.5%

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Wednesday raised its benchmark repo rate by 25 basis points to 5.50 per cent, its first rate increase in nearly four years, and signalled that further hikes could follow as inflationary pressures.

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WINDOWS

Bomb threat at Narendra Modi stadium

AHMEDABAD: A bomb threat email, purportedly from the 'Khalistan National Army', was received at Ahmedabad's Narendra Modi Stadium during an India Under-19 vs Australia Under-19 cricket match, also warning of blasts at upcoming Diljit Dosanjh concerts in Delhi and Ahmedabad. The threat also warned of bomb blasts at JLN Stadium in Delhi and Narendra Modi Stadium in Ahmedabad on specific dates coinciding with Diljit Dosanjh concerts. Both U-19 teams were on the stadium premises and were later evacuated as per protocol after being informed of the threat. Gujarat Cricket Association Secretary Anil Patel confirmed that similar threats had been received previously, including during the World Cup 2023 and IPL.

IRCTC 'scam': HC stays order to frame charges

NEW DELHI: The Delhi High Court has stayed an order directing framing of money laundering charges against Sujata Hotels, an accused in the IRCTC hotel scam case involving former railway minister Lalu Prasad Yadav and others. Justice Sachin Datta issued notice to the Enforcement Directorate (ED) on a petition by Sujata Hotels Pvt Ltd challenging a trial court's September 10 order. The high court granted the probe agency four weeks to file its reply which should refer to the precise material supporting the involvement of the company in the concerned activity falling within the sweep of Section 3 (offence of money laundering) of the PMLA. "Prima facie, the issue as to whether the acts of the directors can be attributed to the company in the peculiar factual context requires further consideration in the context of the above submissions," the court said in its October 5 order.

Lanka's ex-first lady Rajapaksa arrested for fraud

COLOMBO: Sri Lanka's former first lady Shiranthi Rajapaksa was arrested on Wednesday for alleged fraud involving her NGO Sirliya Saviya's bank account. Officers from the Commission to Investigate Allegations of Bribery or Corruption (CIABOC) arrested the wife of former Sri Lanka president Mahinda Rajapaksa at their residence in Polhengoda, a suburb in eastern Colombo.

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Modi promises developed India by 2047

NEW DELHI

MARKING a quarter-century as a head of government, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday coined a new slogan, "We Will Do It," as he reiterated his resolve to transform India into a developed nation by 2047. Addressing the 'Viksit Bharat Sankalp Sabha', Modi asserted that with the collective strength of 140 crore citizens, what once seemed unimaginable is now achievable.

Reflecting on his journey, the Prime Minister noted that when he assumed office as the Chief Minister of Gujarat on October 7, 2001, he

had never envisioned completing 25 continuous years leading governments. "I bow before the people of India for their trust in me. For me, the public is God, and party workers are my strength," Modi expressed, adding that his quarter-century of administrative experience is a shared asset belonging to every child of the nation.

During his address, PM Modi outlined a series of ambitious goals for the nation, invoking the spirit of "We Will Do It" across key operational frontiers—ranging from becoming a top three global economy, achieving self-reliance, and establishing India as a global

● I bow before the people of India for their trust in me. For me, the public is God, and party workers are my strength

● PM cautions against political fragmentation and vote-bank tactics; casteist divisions a major hurdle to N'at progress

manufacturing hub, to stepping into space and hosting the Olympics. However, the Prime Minister cautioned against political fragmentation and vote-bank tactics during elections, identifying casteist divisions as a major hurdle to national progress. Pointing out that developmental crises affect every citizen equally, he stated, "When a farmer's field lacks water

or when electricity fails, it affects everyone regardless of caste or community. If the problem belongs to everyone, the solution must be for everyone." Reaffirming his personal philosophy, Modi credited critics, supporters, and democratic principles for guiding his administrative tenure. "I am a person who lives not for ambition, but for mission," he affirmed,



emphasizing that his daily devotion remains rooted in continuous, selfless service

for the country. Calling on citizens to channel new energy into national resolutions,

he urged the nation to move forward unitedly toward the 2047 milestone.

Rahul, Priyanka removed from protest site, detained

Oppn MPs staged a sit-in at the roundabout itself, with Priyanka Gandhi lying on the road along with other women leaders, while carrying a copy of the Constitution

HANS NEWS SERVICE
NEW DELHI



roundabout itself, with Priyanka Gandhi lying on the road along with other women leaders, while carrying a copy of the Constitution.

Security personnel gathered in large numbers at the site and they first forcibly removed Rahul Gandhi, and put him inside a police bus after carrying him on their shoulders.

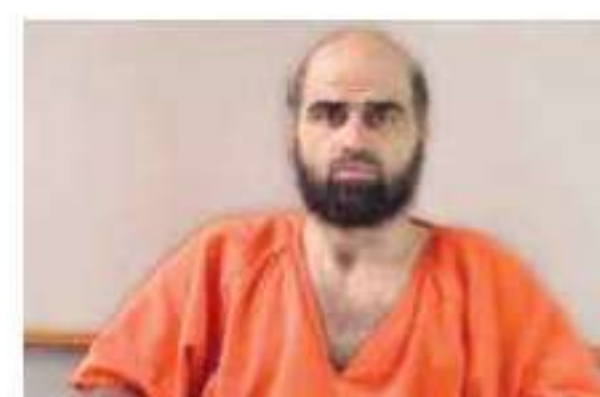
Some of the Congress leaders including Amarinder

Singh Raja Warring and Uday Bhanu Chib alighted atop the bus carrying Rahul Gandhi, while Mumtaz Patel sat on its bonnet.

A large contingent of women police personnel then started removing Priyanka Gandhi and other women who were lying on the road. They were forcibly removed and put into buses and were taken away from the site.

'I want 100 FIRs on me, every FIR is a medal'

NEW DELHI: Leader of the Opposition of Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi said, "Yesterday, they said we cannot protest there, so we are taking the protest to Jantar Mantar... Gyanesh Kumar will have to resign. I want 100 FIRs on me, every FIR is a medal." "We are all here together; we are all here united, and we are all here without any egos. "We will fight the giant till they are out," said TMC MP Derek O'Brien. The objective of the meeting was to draft a letter to the CEC demanding an urgent meeting with opposition leaders on the SIR issues.



Ex US Army major to be executed by firing squad

TEXAS: For the first time in 65 years, an ex-US Army major is scheduled to be executed by a firing squad in Fort Hood Texas, according to the Pentagon. Nidal Malik Hasan, a US Army psychiatrist, killed 13 soldiers and injured 32 at the Fort Hood base in Texas on November 5, 2009. Pentagon spokesperson announced on X that Secretary of Defence Pete Hegseth had recommended Hasan's execution and President Donald Trump has approved it. In his court martial in 2013, Nidal Hasan said that he believed he was protecting Muslims and the Taliban in Afghanistan, reported the BBC. The last US military personnel to be executed in the United States was Private John Bennet. He was hanged in 1961 for the rape and attempted murder of a minor.

Building collapses in city, several feared trapped

HANS NEWS SERVICE
NEW DELHI

AT least five people were injured and several others are feared trapped after a four-storey building collapsed in northeast Delhi's Seemapuri area on Wednesday, with debris burying portions of two to three adjoining houses, officials said.

The Delhi Fire Service (DFS) received a call regarding the front portion of the building collapsing at 3.30 pm and rushed fire tenders to the spot. Delhi Police, civic officials and civil defence personnel also reached the site and launched a search and rescue operation.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (Shahdara) Rajendra Prasad Meena said some people had been rescued and sent to hospitals, while two to three were suspected to be trapped under the debris.

"It's a four-storey building measuring 225 square feet. Some people have been rescued and sent to hospitals,



DCP Meena said some people had been rescued and sent to hospitals, while two to three were suspected to be trapped under the debris

but we suspect that two to three people are still trapped under the debris. They are talking... rescue operation is underway," he said.

Visuals from the spot showed local residents joining the rescue efforts and clearing debris with their bare hands. They were seen removing bricks and rubble from the collapsed structure and helping those trapped underneath. In one video, a group of people could be seen pulling a woman out from under the debris and carrying her away in their arms.

H-1B violators: Bill proposes \$250,000 fine, 10-yr ban

TEXAS: On October 01, 2026, the H-1B Visa Fraud Crackdown Act (H.R. 10643) was introduced by Representative Beth Van Duyne along with five other Republican lawmakers in the US House of Representatives.

H-1B Visa Fraud Crackdown Act seeks to sharply increase penalties and extend debarment periods for employers violating visa rules. The bill proposes a sharp increase in penalties for certain violations of the



H-1B visa programme.

It also includes a maximum fine of \$250,000 and 10-year debarment period for serious violations.

The bill has been referred to the House Judiciary Committee. The bill specifically seeks to amend Section

212(n)(2)(C) of the US Immigration and Nationality Act to introduce the higher penalties. The proposal has not yet become law. It would have to pass Congress and be signed by the President before its provisions could take effect. Last week US Vice President JD Vance strongly criticised the H-1B visa programme, calling it 'completely broken' and advocating for its abolition due to alleged corporate exploitation that displaces American workers.

Court slams police over eyewash in MCOCA case

HANS NEWS SERVICE
NEW DELHI

A Delhi court has slammed the city police for what it called an "absolutely perfunctory and mere eyewash" report in an organised-crime case, in which two accused allegedly continued to commit heinous offences, including murder, for years after the stringent MCOCA was invoked against them but were arrested only in 2026.



Special Judge Gaurav Rao also sent a copy of the order dated October 5 to the Delhi police commissioner, saying the matter "calls for a detailed inquiry and appropriate action against all the erring officials/investigating officers". The case pertains to an

FIR registered in September 2020, in which the Maharashtra Control of Organised Crime Act (MCOCA) was invoked against accused Mukesh alias Punit and Pardeep alias Guri.

The court noted that Mukesh was involved in around 20 FIRs, including two for murder and one for attempt to murder, when the MCOCA was invoked. After that, he was allegedly named in eight more FIRs

between 2021 and 2024, including for murder, attempt to murder, robbery and kidnapping. He was arrested only on February 9, 2026, by Assistant Commissioner of Police (ACP) Rakesh Kumar, after the investigation was assigned to him on September 25, 2025.

"Hence, before ACP Rakesh Kumar, none of the IOs made any efforts to arrest the said accused," the court said.

Jagga Reddy, Nirmala start sit-in protest in Sangareddy in support of Rahul's fight

HANS NEWS SERVICE
SANGAREDDY

TELANGANA PCC working president T Jagga Reddy and his wife Nirmala began a sit-in protest here in support of Lok Sabha Opposition Leader Rahul Gandhi's and other leaders agitation demanding resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar. They started the solidarity sit-in protest at 10 pm along with party activists at the Ambedkar statue, near the old bus stand.

Reddy said Rahul Gandhi is fighting for the voting rights of the people of the country. "Our sit-in protest will continue as long as Rahul's fight continues,"

- Jagga Reddy decides to start sit-in protest in support of agitation by Rahul, Priyanka, Kharge, Venugopal demanding resignation of CEC Gyanesh Kumar
- The protest began at Ambedkar statue near Old Bus Stand at 10 pm on Wednesday
- It will continue for as long as Rahul continues his fight

he said while demanding CEC's resignation. The leaders' agitation, he stated was to protect the voting rights/democratic rights of people.

Speaking on the occasion, Reddy made serious allegations about the functioning of the Election Commission. He alleged that in States where the BJP is strong, the election system was altered to favour

the party and help it come to power. He said the BJP came to power at the Centre three times with the cooperation of the Election Commission, and Rahul Gandhi has raised questions about this on several occasions.

"This is not just a political fight of the Congress Party; it is a political battle to protect the voting rights of the people

of the country. Rahul Gandhi is sitting on the streets and fighting for the rights of the people," Reddy said.

He accused the Election Commission of acting arbitrarily even in the SIR process and said the commission has the responsibility to answer the public regarding the disputes arising over voter lists. He referred to the allegations made by Rahul Gandhi and Priyanka Gandhi that attempts are being made to undermine the voting rights of people. Reddy declared full support for Rahul's agitation demanding the resignation of CEC. He condemned the police for obstructing and detaining Rahul Gandhi, Pri-

yanka Gandhi, and other Opposition leaders in Delhi.

"We will continue our solidarity protest in Sangareddy for as long as Rahul Gandhi continues his fight. Our agitation will continue in support of the demand for Gyanesh Kumar's resignation," he said.

Reddy noted that since the establishment of the independent election system in the country, the Nehru-Gandhi family has always prioritised the protection of democratic institutions. He recalled that former PMs Indira Gandhi and Rajiv Gandhi sacrificed their lives for the nation, and Sonia Gandhi served the public for many years. "Rahul Gandhi, who



comes from a family with a history of sacrifice, is now fighting for the voting rights of people of the country. People should voluntarily stand in support of

his struggle," Reddy appealed. Nirmala, along with party leaders, public representatives, and activists, expressed solidarity with Rahul's agitation.

AAP govt's corruption pot filled to brim, its end near: BJP

HANS NEWS SERVICE
MOHALI

PUNJAB BJP president Kewal Singh Dhillon on Wednesday accused the AAP government of indulging in rampant corruption and pushing the state to "ruin", claiming that its "end is near". His remark came a day after the CBI registered a corruption case involving an OSD to Punjab CM Bhagwant Mann and other senior officers on the directions of the Punjab

and Haryana High Court and conducted searches at multiple locations including Mann's "camp office".

"The corruption pot of the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) has filled to the brim. Cases relating to the alleged loot of public money and corruption are now coming to light. Those who looted Punjab will have to answer to the people of the state," Dhillon said. "The CBI has booked six persons, including two public servants, middle-

The government came to power projecting itself as an "honest government", but cases allegedly linked to corruption and the misuse of public money were now coming to light one after another: Kewal Singh Dhillon

men and associates namely Rajbir Ghuman, Officer on Special Duty (OSD) to Chief Minister, Punjab, Nitin Gohal, Jitin Gohal alias Raja, Romi Raja Mahajan, Bir Devinder, and R S Nagra, and unknown public servant(s) and private person(s)," the agency said.

During a protest by BJP workers against the Mann government here, Dhillon symbolically smashed a pot representing corruption. BJP workers subsequently also burnt an effigy of the AAP government as part of the protest. The AAP government came

to power projecting itself as an "honest government", but cases allegedly linked to corruption and the misuse of public money were now coming to light one after another, Dhillon claimed. He said the people of Punjab are watching the developments closely and would give their verdict at the appropriate time. Referring to corruption-related cases in Punjab, Dhillon alleged that despite the Enforcement Directorate (ED) writing several

times to the Punjab Police, the state government failed to conduct an appropriate investigation, forcing the matter to reach the Punjab and Haryana High Court. He alleged that while action was being taken in the cases, the AAP government appeared "rattled" by the developments. The Punjab BJP chief said that if the AAP government had nothing to hide, it should face the investigations instead of questioning them.



Punjab BJP president Kewal Singh Dhillon

BJP's way of working ahead of elections: Mann on CBI raids

HANS NEWS SERVICE
CHANDIGARH

A day after the CBI raided his officer-on-special duty (OSD) in a corruption case, on Wednesday, Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann said it was the BJP's "way of working" ahead of election and claimed that the agency found nothing incriminating.

The CBI registered a corruption case involving an OSD to Mann and other officers at the direction of the Punjab and Haryana High Court and raided several locations, including the chief minister's "camp office", officials said.

Directing a probe by the federal agency, the high

The CBI registered a corruption case involving an OSD to Mann and other officers at the direction of the Punjab and Haryana High Court and raided several locations, including the chief minister's "camp office"



Mann alleged that whenever an election is due, the party starts "harassing" the opposition leaders, their associates, or their family members through raids months before. "A raid was conducted at Hemant Soren's residence in Chhat-

tisgarh. Elections were due after two months. Similarly, close leaders of Mamata Banerjee in West Bengal were apprehended ahead of elections," he said. Mann also cited the arrest of Arvind Kejriwal and Manish Sisodia in Delhi, and raids by the

Enforcement Directorate in Haryana against Congress leaders, both times ahead of an election, as instances of BJP's power abuse.

"From yesterday's raid, it shows they (BJP) are rattled," he said. "They did not find anything during the raid which lasted 7-8 hours," he claimed. "What will they get from us? We have not come here to indulge in corrupt practices," Mann added. The AAP leader said that maybe the CBI will now give his party a clean chit and will "tell (Narendra) Modi that 'nothing will be found from here and do not waste our time.'" He also accused the BJP of trying to defame him, his family and his government.

Modi's 25 yrs a journey for welfare of poor: Shah in Har

HANS NEWS SERVICE
GURUGRAM

UNION Home Minister Amit Shah on Wednesday hailed Narendra Modi's 25 years in public office, describing the career as a journey for the welfare of the country and for the welfare of the poor.

The day, October 7, is "golden and epochal" in the history of Indian democracy, Shah said, addressing a gathering here. Shah was listening to a speech at the event along with Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini, Union Minister and Gurugram MP Rao Inderjit Singh, and the party's newly appointed Haryana affairs in-charge Smriti Irani. Modi on Wednesday, while addressing the 'Viksit Bharat Sankalp Sabha' on his completion of 25 years as head of government, gave the slogan -- "We Will Do It" -- for the goal of a



developed country by 2047.

Shah here said Modi's years as the head of a government—first in Gujarat and then at the Centre—have been 25 years of welfare for crores of citizens, 25 years of India's pride, and prayed for his long life.

"We have organised this Seva Jyoti Yatra in every district across the country" to make this journey memorable, he said. Shah also praised Modi for powering through

his struggles despite being born in a poor family. "Over these 25 years: freedom from poverty, a secure India, the abrogation of Article 370, the elimination of Naxalism, the construction of the Ram Janmabhoomi and Kashi Vishwanath temples, taking the country's infrastructure to the next level, and lifting 25 crore poor citizens above the poverty line..." Shah said, listing Modi's achievements at the Centre.

UP CEO refutes report alleging 'mysterious' voter addition

HANS NEWS SERVICE
LUCKNOW

THE Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) of Uttar Pradesh has categorically refuted allegations raised in a media report concerning the addition of 16.18 lakh voters during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR), stating that the process was conducted with 'utmost transparency' and in strict adherence to statutory rules.

Issuing a detailed clarification on X, the CEO of Uttar Pradesh stressed that the SIR was executed strictly under the Representation of the People Act, 1950, and



the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960. "The allegations levelled in the report are not correct as these are based on faulty assumptions and are therefore categorically denied. The SIR has been conducted in Uttar Pradesh

with utmost transparency and strictly in accordance with the Representation of the People Act, 1950, the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960 and the extant instructions of the ECI.' 'Specifically, regarding

the allegation of "The Mysterious 16.18 Lakh Voters Added to Uttar Pradesh's Roll", it is clarified that 16.18 Lakh forms (Form-6 for addition of name of a person in the roll) were collected before the date of publication of draft Roll (i.e. before 06.01.2026) during House-to-House visits of BLOs in the Enumeration phase (i.e. from 27-10-2025 to 06-01-2026), the post stated.

The CEO explained that the collection of forms was part of the standard enumeration process initiated as per the Election Commission of India's (ECI) instructions.

U'khand to conduct 3-day camp to add left out voters

HANS NEWS SERVICE
DEHRADUN

THE Uttarakhand Chief Election Officer on Wednesday announced a three-day special in the state from October 8 to October 10 at every polling station to add new voters and those who were "left out" of the voter list due to various reasons during the SIR process despite being eligible for enrollment.

Officials said that during the camp, the BLOs will compare the current electoral roll with the pre-SIR electoral roll and identify such electors whose names were there in the pre-SIR roll but who are



not included in the current electoral roll and prepare a list of such electors.

In Uttarakhand, before the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls started, there were a total of 84,29,459 electors. After the SIR process, the total number of electors stands at 71,58,949. Between January 2025 and August 2026, 4,34,620 voters were added and 17,05,130 voter names

were deleted. The move by the election authorities comes in the backdrop of criticism from opposition parties and other quarters over the deletion of a large number of names during the SIR, with questions being raised about the exercise. B. V. R. C. Purushottam, the chief electoral officer of Uttarakhand, told reporters on Wednesday that the BLOs will ensure filling up of Form 6 for enrollment of any "left out/first time/ young electors" during their house-to-house visits. BLOs will also share this list with booth-level agents (BLAs) of the recognised political parties.

RS polls have set tone for UP Assembly polls: Yogi

HANS NEWS SERVICE
LUCKNOW

UTTAR Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Wednesday said the Rajya Sabha elections in the state have set the tone for the 2027 Assembly polls, claiming the "80 versus 20" political battle was back, with 80 per cent of the electorate with the NDA and 20 per cent with the opposition's PDA. "The Rajya Sabha election (nominations) in Uttar Pradesh showed what the result of the Assembly election is going to be.

The 80 versus 20 fight has returned.

Eighty per cent is with the NDA and 20 per cent with the PDA, and what is going to happen to the PDA will again be before you," Adityanath said while addressing the "Seva Jyoti Yatra-Viksit Bharat Sankalp Sabha" in the state capital. His remarks came a day after eight BJP candidates filed their nominations for the 10 Rajya Sabha seats from Uttar Pradesh, while the Samajwadi Party nominated only two candidates.

SP chief Akhilesh Yadav had hinted at fielding a third candidate but on the last date of nomination on Tuesday he said its his party's focus is not on three seats but on the 403 Assembly seats in Uttar Pradesh.

Yadav had earlier stated that his party would field a third candidate once the required numbers are secured.

With no third candidate being fielded by the SP, all 10 nominees are set to be elected unopposed, subject to the completion of the electoral process.

FIR against 109 for obstructing Ganesh idol immersion procession

BAHRAICH : An FIR has been registered against nine named persons, including a district panchayat member, and around 100 unidentified people for allegedly obstructing a Ganesh idol immersion procession, making objectionable remarks and threatening participants with death here, officials said on Wednesday. Two accused have been arrested in connection with the case, they said.

According to the police, the FIR was registered at Fakharpur police station on October 5 based on a complaint lodged by Omkar Nath, priest of the Shri Ram Janaki Temple in Madhavpur village. The incident mentioned in the FIR allegedly took place on September 25. Fakharpur Station House Officer (SHO)

Ram Kumar Rajbhar said the complainant alleged that people carrying a Ganesh idol installed at the temple for immersion as part of a traditional procession were stopped from proceeding further at Khalidpur. The accused allegedly made objectionable remarks and abused those participating in the procession, besides threatening them with death, the SHO said.

Police were informed after the situation became tense and the idol was subsequently taken for immersion under police supervision, he said.

The FIR names Maulana Sarwar, Hasir Khan alias Namoon, Kalamuddin Ansari, Anil Mulla Qureshi and Sabit Ali among the nine accused, besides around 100 unidentified persons.

Army personnel found dead in Meerut hotel bathroom

HANS NEWS SERVICE
MEERUT

A 34-year-old Army personnel was found dead in the bathroom of a hotel in the Begumpal area here, with police suspecting cardiac arrest as the cause of death. The deceased, identified as Havaladar Parvinder Singh, a native of Ambala, was posted with the Bengal Engineer Group in Roorkee, police said on Wednesday.

Circle Officer (Cantonment) Sanjay Gupta said police received information around 5 pm on Tuesday that Singh had died in the bathroom of a hotel in the Sadar Bazar area. Police and



military police personnel reached the spot and initiated an investigation, he said.

According to Gupta, Singh had been unwell for some time and was undergoing treatment at the military hospital in Meerut Cantonment. He was discharged and was travelling towards Roorkee with Naik Saurabh Singh and Yashveer Singh. The three stopped at the hotel to rest as they had to board a bus

to Roorkee from Begumpal, police said. After reaching the hotel, Parvinder went into the bathroom but did not come out for a long time. When Saurabh and Yashveer knocked on the door and received no response, they sought help from the hotel staff. The door was subsequently broken open, and Parvinder was found lying on the bathroom floor, police said. A forensic team examined the spot and the body was sent for postmortem, police said, adding that cardiac arrest was suspected to be the cause of death. The exact cause, however, would be established after the post-mortem report is received.

Gehlot slams FIR against Rahul, Priyanka in Delhi

HANS NEWS SERVICE
JAIPUR

FORMER Rajasthan chief minister Ashok Gehlot on Wednesday criticised the registration of an FIR against Congress leaders Rahul Gandhi and Priyanka Gandhi Vadra in connection with their entry into the Akashvani Bhawan premises during a protest in New Delhi. Gehlot said the situation in the country was "very delicate" and should be a matter of concern for citizens.

"FIRs will be registered. They can do anything," Gehlot told reporters here, referring to the action against the Gandhi siblings. He also criticised the alleged police treatment of Congress general secretary K C Venugopal during Tuesday's protest.

Delhi Police registered the

FIR after receiving a complaint alleging that Rahul Gandhi, Priyanka Gandhi and other MPs entered the Akashvani Bhawan premises without permission during the Opposition's protest against the Election Commission.

Gehlot said the Election Commission members could have met INDIA bloc leaders in Parliament's Annex to address the controversy over "vote chori" allegations and the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

He also expressed concern over what he described as a threat to democracy and said the issue should concern young people as the country's future belonged to them.

Opposition MPs had attempted to march from Parliament towards the Election Commission office but were stopped by police.

VHP asks filmmaker Vivek to apologise for 'tax religion' remark

HANS NEWS SERVICE
NEW DELHI

THE Vishva Hindu Parishad (VHP) on Wednesday asked filmmaker Vivek Agnihotri to withdraw his statement related to "tax religion" in the context of people visiting religious sites and apologise, keeping in mind the sentiments of crores of devout Hindus.

The remarks came after Agnihotri reposted a video clip on X of a huge crowd

jostling in queues while visiting Kaichi Dham in Uttarakhand on October 4. Along with the post, he wrote that if only the government could tax religion, India would become the richest country overnight. "Not because people would pay the tax. But because they would quit religion and start focusing on innovation, progress, productivity and ideas.

"They would finally try to become rich themselves, in-

"Why describe the pilgrimages of crores of Hindus as 'waiting for miracles' and pit religion against innovation and productivity? Pilgrimage sites are the soul of India. They are not merely places of worship; they are deeply connected with our civilisation, culture, social life and local economies

stead of waiting for miracles or divine interventions," he wrote. Reacting to the post, VHP national spokesperson Vinod Bansal criticised Agnihotri for pitting religion against innovation and pro-

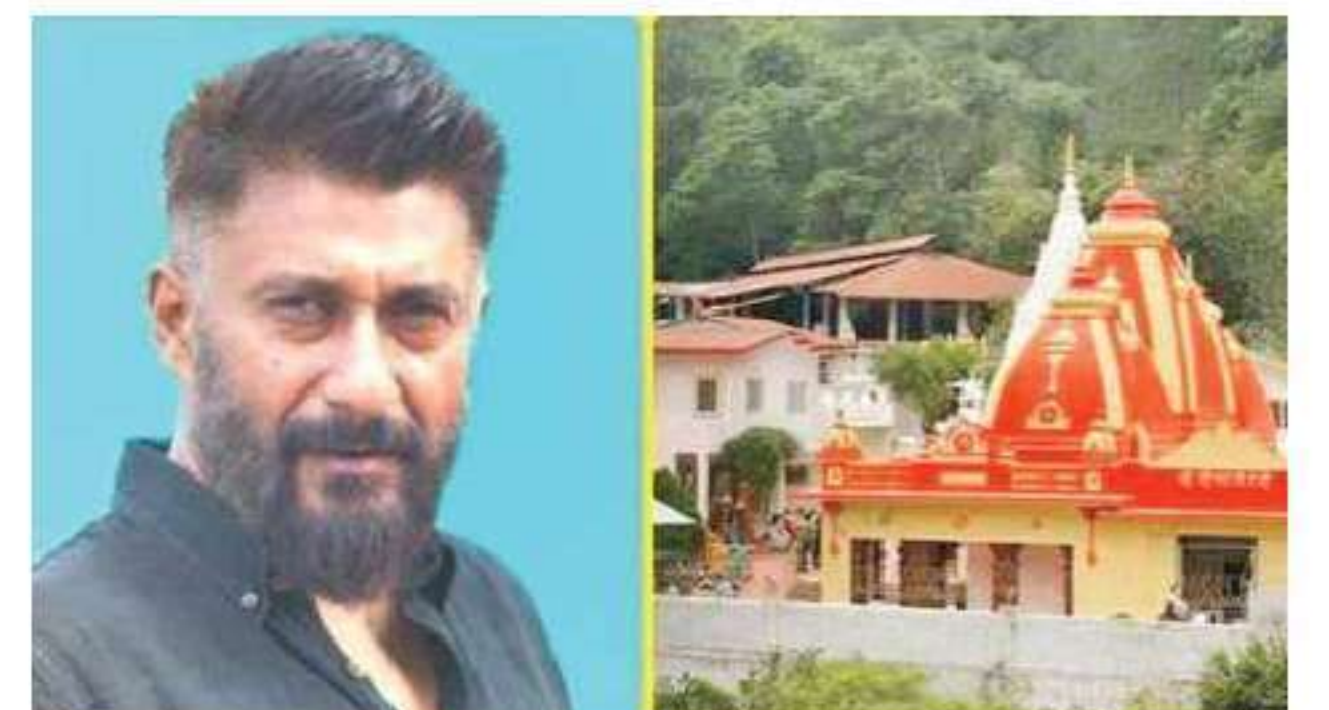
ductivity. "Why describe the pilgrimages of crores of Hindus as 'waiting for miracles' and pit religion against innovation and productivity? Pilgrimage sites are the

soul of India. They are not merely places of worship; they are deeply connected with our civilisation, culture, social life and local economies," Bansal said in a post on X.

He also questioned Agnihotri over his reference to a "religion tax", saying the film industry seeks tax exemptions for its films. "The film industry seeks tax exemptions for its films, but when it comes to pilgrimage sites, why talk about a reli-

gion tax?" he said. Bansal also questioned whether the remarks were linked to the promotion of a new film.

"Vivek ji, has this distasteful idea polluted your mind because of the promotion of some new film? This is the same faithful, religious and nationalist Hindu society that not only made your films successful and helped you grow, but also placed you on a pedestal through your films. It is not appropriate for you to



play with their deep faith," Bansal said. "You were not like this! Therefore, the

question arises: Has someone prompted you to say this?" he said.

Four juveniles apprehended for firing, knife attack

**HANS NEWS SERVICE
NEW DELHI**

THE Delhi Police has apprehended four juveniles in connection with a firing and knife attack at a house in Shahdara here, allegedly carried out to avenge a man's murder in Seemapuri last year, officials said on Wednesday.

Police said they apprehended the juveniles, all aged 17, on October 7, and recovered a semi-automatic pistol, two live cartridges and two kitchen knives allegedly used in the crime from them.

Four empty shells were recovered from the spot, they said. The incident happened on at around 9.20 pm when a PCR call was received at Farsh

Police said they apprehended the juveniles, all aged 17, and recovered a semi-automatic pistol, two live cartridges and two kitchen knives allegedly used in the crime from them

Bazar police station stating that some people entered a house in Bhikham Singh Colony and fired three to four rounds. On reaching the spot, police found 21-year-old

Javed with a bullet injury to his left forearm and knife injuries on the left side of his neck.

Officials said his maternal aunt, Maimoona Bibi, 31, had also sustained knife injuries

on the left and rear side of her neck. Both the injured were initially taken to Hedgewar Hospital.

Farsh Bazar police station registered a case under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and the Arms Act. During the investigation, police found that Javed was an accused in a 2025 murder case registered at Seemapuri police

station in connection with the killing of Akbar, a bad character of Shastri Park Police Station, they said.

Police said seven accused had already been arrested in that case, while Javed had been absconding and was being searched by law-enforcement agencies. He had recently shifted with his family to a rented accommodation in



Bhikham Singh Colony, police said. Police examined CCTV footage and developed local intelligence to identify those involved in the attack, apprehending four juveniles.

'Protests against CEC has evolved into a broader citizens' movement'

**HANS NEWS SERVICE
NEW DELHI**

ALL India Students' Association (AISA) national president Neha Bora said the ongoing protests against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar had evolved into a broader citizens' movement, asserting that people would continue to raise questions over democracy, electoral rolls and the right to protest.

Bora recalled the citizens' call for a march on September 25 and said several activists, lawyers and public representatives had joined the initiative, including political activist Yogendra Yadav, Right to Information activist Anjali Bhardwaj, Rajya Sabha MP Manoj Jha and TMC MP Mahua Moitra.

She said the participation of these individuals reflected a broader effort to raise the issues in a "consolidated manner" and with the same unity that had been witnessed during education-related movements in the past few months.



Bora said subsequent calls for protests were made on October 2, with a citizens' call in Delhi at Jantar Mantar and a separate call by the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) in Mumbai.

She claimed that the participation in both cities sent a message that concerns over the electoral process and alleged voter disenfranchisement had become an urgent issue for citizens.

"The massive turnout in Mumbai on October 2 sends a clear message that if there is one urgent, the most urgent, issue at this point, it is the theft of democracy and the theft of votes," Bora said.

Four held in fake currency racket

**HANS NEWS SERVICE
NEW DELHI**

THE Delhi Police has busted a counterfeit currency racket and recovered suspected fake notes with a face value of around Rs 10.50 lakh, officials said on Wednesday. Police arrested four people who were allegedly involved in procuring material, preparing and circulating counterfeit Rs 500 notes, police said.

Acting on a tip-off regarding the movement and supply of counterfeit currency in the Prashant Vihar area, the police team conducted a raid near Japanese Park and apprehended Pushkar Raj Purbia alias "Doctor"

During further investigation, the police conducted sustained questioning and technical surveillance, which led them to Narendra Kumar (31), who was subsequently apprehended from Churu in Rajasthan

(56), Gosai Ram (22) and Sahil Kharb (28). Suspected counterfeit Rs 500 notes and equipment used for printing them were recovered from them, following which an FIR was registered, they said. During further investigation, the police conducted



sustained questioning and technical surveillance, which led them to Narendra Kumar (31), who was subsequently apprehended from Churu in Rajasthan.

Searches at premises linked to the accused led to the recovery of printing equipment, digital devices, printing material and other articles suspected to have been used in preparing counterfeit currency notes,

they said.

A total of 21 bundles containing suspected counterfeit Rs 500 notes, having a face value of approximately Rs 10.50 lakh, were recovered during the operation and subsequent investigation, police said. The seized material includes two colour printers, a paper-cutting machine, two HP laptops, a note-counting machine, screen-printing material, a desktop computer with monitor, a LCD monitor and a CPU, officials said. Blank papers with ribbons and blank security papers incorporating high-security features were also recovered, they added.

Barapullah design faults AAP's legacy: Minister

**HANS NEWS SERVICE
NEW DELHI**

PINNING the blame on the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) for the Barapullah Phase-III traffic mess, PWD Minister Parvesh Verma on Wednesday said the entire project was planned and designed by the party's government and a solution is in works to correct the faults. Since its opening last month, the stretch has seen crawling traffic because of several design shortcomings.

The Delhi Traffic Police has also written to the Public Works Department (PWD) highlighting the issues. "We recently held a meeting and discussions were on short-term and long-term solutions that have been suggested by traffic police; we will work on that," Verma said. The BJP

leader said the traffic jam on Barapullah indicates that the Arvind Kejriwal government lacked foresight. "All tender specifications, technical feasibility were done by the AAP government. How can this be our design fault?" he added. The minister said his department seeks to undo the faults "as soon as possible" with all administrative issues already resolved. The PWD department is in touch with Google Maps for real-time traffic congestion information about the Barapullah Phase III stretch, he said. "Google Maps algorithm takes around 15 days to update the traffic situation of a road, so that will happen soon; we are in touch with them," Verma said.



Need to focus on fulfilling promises under Paris Agreement: Bhupender

**HANS NEWS SERVICE
NEW DELHI**

UNION Environment Minister Bhupender Yadav on Wednesday called for greater focus on closing gaps in understanding, fulfilling existing climate commitments, and accelerating implementation of the 2015 Paris Agreement. He made the remarks while addressing the leaders' plenary in Fiji as part of the pre-COP31 meetings co-hosted by Australia, Fiji, and Tuvalu. COP31, or the UN Climate Change Conference, will be held in November in Turkey's Antalya.

Pre-COP is a preparatory meeting held a few weeks before the conference. Yadav said there is a need to identify existing gaps in understanding and build consensus on addressing them, including gaps between science and traditional knowledge and community practices, between practices and

ethics, and between available resources and felt needs.

Speaking about implementation, the minister highlighted the need to address identified gaps where the need is highest, and the impact is visible and felt by the majority.

Yadav emphasised the need for greater capacity building and urged member countries to bring concrete examples and success stories every year, demonstrating high-impact mitigation, large-scale adaptation, and effective delivery of means of implementation. "Consistently sharing and scaling such examples year after year would yield better results on the ground in achieving the goals of the Paris Agreement," said Yadav.



PM OFFERS PRAYERS AT SHRI VINAYAKA TEMPLE

Prime Minister Narendra Modi offered prayers at the Shri Vinayaka Temple to mark the completion of 25 years as head of government and renewed his pledge to serve the country with utmost dedication. Modi has been continuously serving as head of government – first as chief minister of Gujarat for three terms and subsequently as prime minister of India after winning three Lok Sabha elections – since October 7, 2001. "Performed puja and offered prayers at the Shri Vinayaka Temple in New Delhi. Prayed to Lord Shri Ganesha for the happiness, prosperity, and good health of all my family members across the country."

HC judge recuses from hearing Gymkhana Club eviction case

**HANS NEWS SERVICE
NEW DELHI**

DELHI High Court judge Justice Prateek Jalan on Wednesday recused himself from hearing a case over the Centre's proceedings against the Delhi Gymkhana Club for its eviction from the 27.3-acre premises on Safdarjung Road here. Justice Jalan directed that the lawsuit by the Delhi Gymkhana Club Ltd Staff Welfare Association be listed before another bench on Friday.

"I am going to recuse from this matter. There are matters where one does not trust one's own judgement," Justice Jalan said. "There is too much personal involved. I will feel more comfortable if someone else heard it," he said without elaborating.

Gymkhana member Vijay Khurana and Delhi Gymkhana Club Ltd Staff Welfare Association have filed separate lawsuits against the Land and Development Office (L&DO)'s May 22 order terminating the colonial-era club's perpetual lease deed and asking it to return its land by June 5 on grounds of "strengthening and securing defence infrastructure".

Khurana's lawsuit is stated to be supported by more than 500 club members. They have also filed applications seeking a stay on the June 29 show-cause notice for eviction issued to the club's management by an estate officer of the L&DO. The Centre had earlier said it would not take any coercive action in relation to the eviction for the time being. The Centre, in its response to the main matter, has asserted that lawsuits were liable to be dismissed. It had said that third parties cannot restrain the enforcement of rights arising from the now-determined lease deed between the authorities and the club for the land parcel.



Shubhankar hoping to strike form at DP World India Championship

**HANS NEWS SERVICE
NEW DELHI**

TOP Indian golfer Shubhankar Sharma is hoping to rediscover his form at the DP World India Championship after ironing out a few issues in his game as he eyes a return to the winners' circle at the Delhi Golf Club. As a young golfer, Sharma spent hours honing his skills at the Delhi Golf Club and the 30-year-old will return to the iconic venue for the USD 4 million event, which will feature some of the world's best players, including three of the four reigning Major champions from this year.

The tournament is scheduled from October 15 to 18. "For us Indians, it means a lot. I don't think I can say more. I can't say enough about how special the event is and how special and iconic the venue is," he said in a release.

"Personally, we're looking forward to the event. I have some very special memories at the Delhi Golf Club, from my days as a kid, when I even attended a clinic by Ernie Els." It has not been the easiest season for Sharma, who has endured a series of missed cuts. A shift in equipment, including new shafts in his clubs, added another layer of adjustment, but there have been glimpses that his game is not far away.

At the Omega European Masters in September, Sharma produced a superb six-under 64 in the opening round but slipped back over the weekend.



Oat cookies, sambar rice on menu Mid-day meals at MCD schools to get children-friendly makeover

**MANSI JAGANI
NEW DELHI**

OATS cookies, fruit, kheer, and sambar rice will soon become part of the mid-day meals served to children in MCD schools, with the civic body planning a more varied menu across its nearly 1,500 schools from November, officials said on Wednesday.

They added that the new agencies that will run its school kitchens have been asked to add at least one "special" item to the regular meal every day to make nutritious food more appealing to children.

Oatcakes and cookies are among the options being considered, apart from fruit and kheer, officials at the civic body said. "We are asking the companies to do something additional.

'Children get bored if they keep eating the same thing. If the same ingredients are made into something like a cookie or prepared in a way that children enjoy, they are more likely to eat it'

Children get bored if they keep eating the same thing. If the same ingredients are made into something like a cookie or prepared in a way that children enjoy, they are more likely to eat it," a senior MCD official said.

The revised menu will include sambar rice and continue meals being served currently, such as puri-aloo, dal-rice, and chole-rice. The agencies will also be asked to introduce more variety in the preparations, with hal-

wa made of wheat and ragi to be served twice a week, officials said.

"On days when puri-aloo is served, children like it. We want them to eat everything, so the effort is to change the preparation rather than simply remove an item from the menu," another official said.

The changes come as the MCD prepares to hand over its school kitchens to a new set of agencies. The tender was floated around two months ago and surveys of shortlisted kitchens are underway. Officials said 13 new vendors are expected to come in, and the agencies are likely to be finalised by next week. The civic body has also asked the agencies to work within their available kitchen infrastructure while introducing the additional items.



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Gyanesh Kumar finds himself in a tight corner amid protests

WITH Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi innovating protest methods and other activists threatening to intensify their campaign against Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar, both the Narendra Modi government and the CEC find themselves in a tight corner. Kumar's position is increasingly untenable; whether the charges that he is favouring the Bharatiya Janata Party and running the constitutional body unilaterally matters no more given that he is widely seen as doing so. Media reports showing the two Election Commissioners, S S Sandhu and Vivek Joshi, officially objecting to Kumar's style of functioning have not just made Kumar

vulnerable to allegations of favouritism, but also brought the poll panel under a cloud of suspicion. This is bad for the constitutional body and our democracy. Meanwhile, Rahul seems to be enjoying himself. Enscorced under a banyan tree at the iconic Akashvani Bhavan campus on Monday, he made the premises of the historic building the new site for political protests—perhaps for the first time in the history of All India Radio. The original plan was reportedly to march from the Parliament House to Nirvachan Sadan, the Election Commission headquarters, but the police didn't allow that. Unbothered, leaders of the grand old party invented a new protest site, grabbing a lot of media space,

with news channels showing him for hours continuously and newspapers the next day.

This must be galling to the government and BJP leaders who are always keen to be in the spotlight. The man they have lampooned and lambasted for years is now stealing their thunder from right under their nose. But the saffron establishment itself is responsible for the momentum that the Leader of the Opposition is gaining in the political arena. For years, the BJP and its leaders have treated Rahul Gandhi as an object of ridicule rather than as a serious political adversary. He has been caricatured, mocked, and routinely dismissed as being politically immature. Yet politics, like nature, abhors a vacuum.

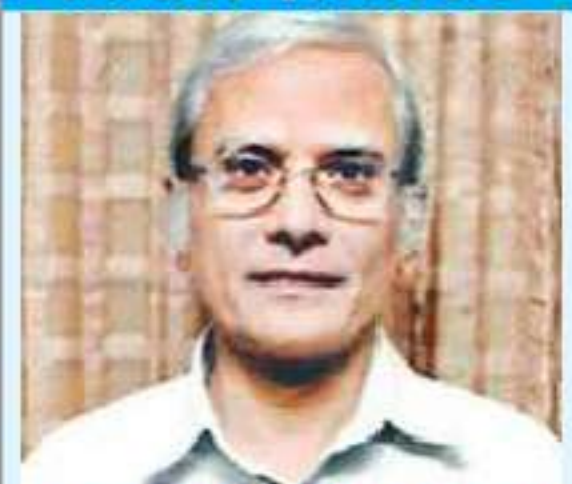
When the ruling establishment concentrates too much on belittling an opponent, it can inadvertently confer upon him precisely the visibility and political relevance that it seeks to deny him. The more the BJP attacks Rahul, the more the Opposition leader is able to present himself as a persecuted challenger taking on an all-powerful establishment.

The same mistake appears to have been repeated in the Election Commission controversy. Instead of allowing the issue to be settled through institutional transparency and credible explanations, the government and the BJP have often responded to criticism by attacking its political provenance. That may satisfy the party faithful, but it does little to ad-

dress the underlying public perception. In a democracy, institutions do not derive their legitimacy merely from their constitutional status; they derive it from the confidence of citizens that they are impartial. If that confidence is eroded, dismissing the critics as politically motivated does not restore it. The government should not prolong its own misery; it must ensure that Kumar resigns (he cannot be dismissed by the government without impeachment). From the government's perspective, he is damaged goods. His removal will be a victory for the Opposition, but it will also take away a talking point from anti-government leaders and activists. This will help the government politically.

'Seva aur Nishtha': CRPF leads from the front

TALKING OF MANY THINGS



DR MOHAN KANDA

OCTOBER 1 marks historical milestones for the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF), including operational sacrifices and administrative landmarks. Every year, since 1969, on 1 October, the Force pays solemn tribute to Constable G D Govind Singh of the 62 Battalion in memory of his supreme sacrifice while fighting gallantly against Maoists during a critical anti-naxalite operation in Ramagundam town in Telangana state. The same day also marks a day of mourning for the passing of retired IPS officer Dr Trinath Mishra, a highly respected former Director General of the Force who passed away on that day this year.

CRPF Raising Day is observed every 27 July to mark the establishment of the Force and to honour the courage, dedication, and sacrifices of CRPF personnel who serve the nation with dedication.

Established as the crown representative's police on the cusp of the Second World War in 1939, the Force was later given its present name following India's independence. Born in Neemuch, with the motto of 'Service and Loyalty', ('Seva aur Nishtha'), it is the largest Central Paramilitary Force.

The Force assists states in the maintenance of law and order, combating insurgencies and

protecting national interests internally.

Strangely enough, I had occasion to interact closely with both the Indian Army, and the Central Paramilitary Forces, once in the very beginning of my IAS days and, again, after superannuation and towards the end of my career in public service.

In 1972, there was a prolonged and widespread public agitation demanding a separate Andhra state.

When things got out of hand at a point, the central government stepped in. The Chief Minister and council of ministers were asked to resign, and President's rule was imposed. The Governor, along with advisers, took over the reins of the government. First the Indian Army and then CRPF were called in to bring a modicum of control over the uncontrollable law and order situation which was fast becoming uncontrollable.

Use of the army was confined to staging a few route marches to instil confidence in the public. The CRPF and BSF, took an active part in maintaining law and order even as the Telangana region remained peaceful.

The most impressive aspect of the presence of the central forces was that they were self-contained units and only needed some land where they could pitch their tents and get down to business.

On the 22nd of November 1972 the police in Ongole town had to resort to lathi-charge and tear-gas to disperse a crowd of agitators. When those measures failed, they opened fire killing four people. Curfew was imposed in the town and shoot-at-sight orders were enforced.

As the Sub Collector of Ongole at that time, I was then camping at Chirala, which was

Every year, since 1969, on 1 October, the Force pays solemn tribute to Constable G D Govind Singh of the 62 Battalion in memory of his supreme sacrifice while fighting gallantly against Maoists during a critical anti-naxalite operation in Ramagundam

in my jurisdiction. The Collector of the district summoned me back to Ongole. As I was entering the town, I could see flames rising into the sky as several buildings had been set afire by the angry mob fleeing from the place of the incident. A group of agitating youth stopped me from entering the town as they felt that my presence would strengthen the hands of the official machinery. It was only after patiently persuading them that I would have a constructive role to play in restoring peace and order that I was allowed to enter. The Collector, the Superintendent of Police and I discussed in detail the measures to bring the situation under control.

Quite obviously the administration had lost contact with the people, who were upset and furious. None was willing to participate in any discussions. As several attempts to bring to the table prominent citizens who could assist in the process proved to be of no avail, it was clear to us that the situation called for out-of-the-box thinking.

The Superintendent of Police and I hit upon a bright idea. Karavadi Venkateswarulu was a well-known lawyer who enjoyed considerable goodwill with the citizens of the town. Known to be of socialistic persuasion, he was a person with whom I had

cordial relations. Deliberately, as a ploy, we had taken him into custody and detained overnight, an action both legally permissible and possible to defend under the circumstances. The move outraged the city community with both the youth and elders expressing dismay at the turn of events. Sure enough, and as expected, several leading citizens sought a meeting with us the next morning. This gave us the opportunity we wanted to re-establish a rapport with the people.

As earlier planned, we retraced the step of detaining Venkateswarulu. But we had, in the process, managed to secure the cooperation of the leaders. We proceeded to form a Peace Committee to oversee the measures to restore normalcy and a sense of confidence and trust in the administration.

Soon thereafter, the situation improved and normalcy was gradually restored.

Everyone likes to study and understand the lineage and learn about their forefathers. I am afraid such an attempt, in my case, did not go too far. I stopped at the stage at which the branches of the ancestral tree showed my great grandfather as having served in the army of the Peshwa Indore. It is probably that streak in my personality that made me inherit an affinity towards peo-

ple in uniform. Naturally, especially as almost everyone else on the civil side was on strike, I made close friends with the officers in charge of the units and often enjoyed hot pakodas and a couple of shots of rum in the evening with them.

An incident that stands out in my memory is one that happened one day in Chirala, a part of my subdivision. The Communist Party of India (CPI) decided that it should make known to the public its stand against the ongoing agitation and took out a procession, a dangerous and highly ill-advised move at that sensitive time when passions were riding high, and the slightest provocation was enough to cause an explosive situation. Things, however, cannot be stopped in a democracy and, by way of ensuring prevention of any disruption or violence, I led an impressive posse of the BSF from the front with the CPI contingent behind me. The local media, in fact, were to remark that my procession was larger than that of the CPI!

One danger everyone had to guard against in such situations those days was that of soda bottles, made of thick glass with marbles stuck in their necks; pressing downwards caused the soda to appear being filled with gramophone needles instead of soda water. When they were hurled as missiles, they would burst upon landing on the ground and spray the needles all around. A dangerous weapon indeed!

The somewhat orderly proceedings of the procession were violently interrupted when, suddenly, one such soda bottle landed in front of my vehicle and burst open, sprinkling sharp needles in all directions. Unharmful though we were,

that was enough to create chaos among the members of the procession, who ran helter skelter. One of the BSF jawans charged at the miscreant who had thrown the bottle, lathi in hand. When I tried to stop him, he shouted at me saying "Sir, Meri Fauji ki izzat ki baat hai."

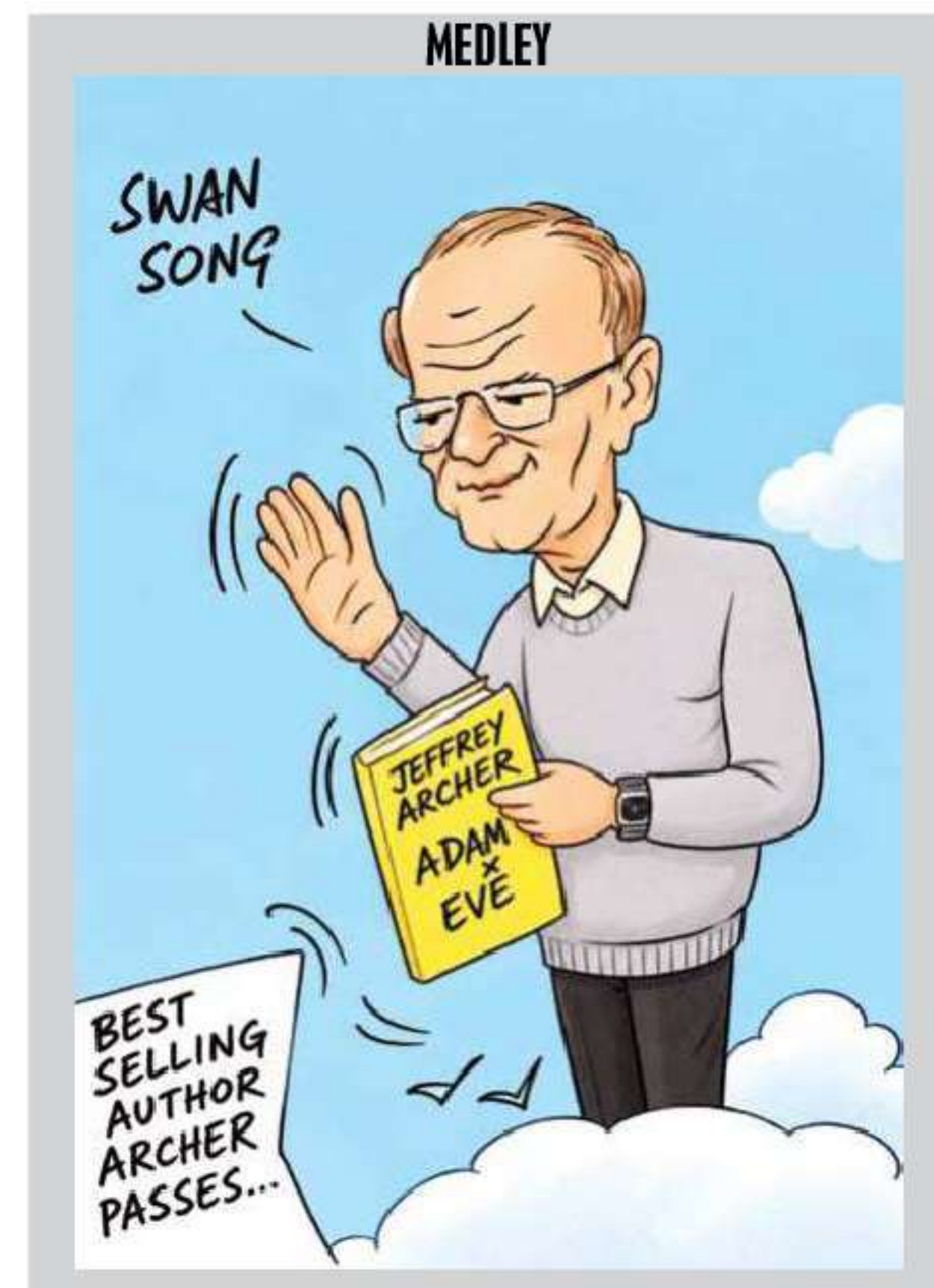
The pride of the unit had been offended, and it took all the persuasive abilities at my command to prevent the situation from deteriorating further. Such are the qualities which make the central paramilitary forces so valuable in situations such as those.

And, again, it was during the early days of my tenure as a Member of the National Disaster Management Authority that I had another opportunity to study at close quarters the ability of the CPMF to rise to the occasion.

CRPF, together with its three counterparts-CISE, the BSF and the ITBF—were drafted into the newly formed National Disaster Response Force. Duly trained and equipped, it proved to be an invaluable instrument in the nation's fight against the impact of natural disasters and the people and property, namely in rescue and relief operations.

I remember how in college days, as a cadet of the NCC, one got into the uniform and, rifle slung over the shoulder and basking in the winter sun of Delhi, marched all the way from Hindu College in the North Campus of Delhi University to India Gate. I must confess that the lure of the Rs 1.67 that awaited one at the end of the ordeal, as a reward that translated into a bread pakoda and a bottle of Coca-Cola, played a great role in keeping me going.

(The writer was formerly Chief Secretary, Government of Andhra Pradesh)



LETTERS

A master storyteller

JEFFREY Archer was a master storyteller who kept millions of readers spellbound and, many a time, gasping for breath as they turned the pages of his thrillers. His literary journey began in 1976 with his debut novel Not a Penny More, Not a Penny Less, and fittingly reached its final chapter with Adam & Eve, released on October 6, just a day after his death. This marked the culmination of a remarkable 50-year writing career during which more than 300 million copies of his books were sold worldwide. Archer famously said, "People who survived are storytellers." How true those words proved to be in his own life! He survived numerous troubles and tribulations and repeatedly reinvented himself, eventually becoming one of the world's most celebrated storytellers. His life itself reads like one of his own novels with unexpected twists, setbacks, comebacks and, above all, an enduring passion for storytelling.

Tharcus S Fernando, Chennai-92

The great survivor

JEFFREY Archer has died at 86, and fittingly, "between writing sessions," a phrase that captures a man who never truly stopped creating even after his political career ended in disgrace and prison. His life asks us to reconsider how we judge legacy, whether by one disgraceful chapter or by the fuller arc of reinvention that followed it. Few public figures manage to rebuild so completely after public shame. Perhaps Archer's truest lesson is that redemption, though rarely spoken of kindly in public life, remains possible when talent and persistence refuse to surrender to disgrace. In the end, he leaves behind not scandal but stories, millions of them, still open on bedside tables across the world.

K Chidanand Kumar, Bengaluru

Archer will live on forever

THE passing of Lord Jeffrey Archer marks the end of an extraordinary era in contemporary commercial literature. From the timeless, generation-spanning rivalry of Kane and Abel to the intricate multi-volume tapestry of The Clifton Chronicles, his gift for unputdownable narrative arcs, relentless cliffhangers, and vibrant characterizations defined the modern page-turner. It is both deeply tragic and profoundly poetic that he passed away "between writing sessions," working dedicatedly until his final hours. The arrival of his highly anticipated, just-released World War II epic, Adam & Eve, now bears the bittersweet weight of being his definitive final masterpiece — a novel he proudly believed would rival the finest work of his entire career. Though the master storyteller is no more, his sprawling imagination, his indelible spirit, and the joy he brought to generations of book lovers will live on forever.

Ranganathan Sivakumar, Chennai-603210

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KBR Park: A thoughtless, ruthless and axe-first government calling the shots



DR DASOJU SRAVAN KUMAR

THE birds of a forest once decided to tear down the great tree that held their nests to build more grand ones. They began hacking at once, and nests came crashing down. Then a little sparrow asked, "Why not just fly to the tree next door?" The felling stopped. An old crow sighed, "Had you thought of this at the start, the tree would still stand and none of us would have lost a thing." Today, that crow's sigh is the sigh of every Hyderabad.

Hyderabad deserves roads that move. Nobody disputes that. What it does not deserve is a government that swings the axe first and opens the file later. Around Kasu Brahmananda Reddy (KBR) National Park, the trees are gone, the money is gone, and the plan meant to justify both has been thrown into the dustbin.

Numbers do not lie:

In 2024, the government sanctioned around Rs 826 crore under H-CITI for seven flyovers and seven underpasses

around KBR Park, from Jubilee Hills check post and the park's main gate to Road Nos. 2, 10, 12, 45 and Film Nagar. Even before a single structure stood, the estimate had ballooned to Rs 1,090 crore: a 32 per cent jump on paper alone.

The government's own proposal listed 1,942 trees: 1,532 to be felled, 380 to be uprooted, and just 30 to be spared. By May 16, nearly 2,000 mature trees had been cut down or savagely lopped. Foundations came up near LV Prasad Eye Institute and Jubilee Hills check post; pits were dug at the Maharaaja Agrasana and Cancer Hospital junctions. Then came the about-turn. In August 2026, a simple one-way system was introduced around the park; joint police and GHMC inspection found that traffic was flowing smoothly. On October 3, the GHMC Standing Committee scrapped the junction plan and approved a single elevated corridor instead. Let that sink in. A few signboards and a handful of traffic constables achieved what a Rs 1,090-crore project could not. The cheapest solution sat in plain sight, and nobody in power tried it before the chainsaws roared. That is not planning. That is vandalism with a budget. Why was a one-way trial not run before 2,000 trees were sacrificed?

They were warned-They did it anyway:

This was not ignorance; it



bordered on arrogance. Since 2015, the KBR flyover had been stuck because the Eco-Sensitive Zone blocked central clearances and the NGT was hearing a case. GHMC itself shelved it in 2020. A year later, the High Court stayed tree felling and demanded an affidavit on the trees' age and regrowth time. Every red flag was flying, yet this government dug the dead project out of its grave, renamed it and made it bigger.

Citizens pleaded with the High Court: no public hearing, no Environmental Impact Assessment, no pollution study. The hearing was adjourned. The court went on vacation. The axes did not.

"Save KBR" protesters reportedly faced midnight arrests. Only on May 18, did the Supreme Court halt felling within 25 to 35 metres of the park boundary. The government did not protect KBR. The Supreme Court had to protect it from the government.

A tree is not timber. It is life:

Many of those trees were older than Telangana itself. They sheltered peacocks and nesting birds, cooled morning walkers and filtered a choking city's air. Sapling planted today needs a generation to return what one afternoon destroyed. KBR is one of the last green lungs of a city turning to concrete, and this government took a blade to it. No Government Order can raise 2,000 dead trees. No press release can replant them.

They count the savings but not the losses?

GHMC now boasts that the new plan will save Rs 1,200 crore: Rs 800 crore on land acquisition and Rs 400 crore on construction. On the losses from the plan it just buried, not one word. Boasting of future savings while hiding past waste is not prudence; it is evasion.

How much has already been spent? What happens to the

poured foundations and dug pits? How much went to contractors, and what will cancellation cost? How much of the old work can the new design use? Lest one forgets, every rupee is a taxpayer's rupee.

Worse, nobody can say where the new corridor starts or ends. One newspaper says NFCL in Panjagutta, another 7.5 km flyover to Muffakham Jah College, a third Nagarjuna Circle. No one knows, yet the approval is stamped. And it is sold with the same glossy promises as the old plan: six lanes, signal-free, no harm to greenery. If it truly is better, we will welcome it. But "trust us" is exactly what we were told last time.

Not one blunder but a habit:

This government runs on a five-step script: Announce. Bulldoze. Get rapped by the court. U-turn. Repeat.

Kancha Gachibowli: To auction 400 acres beside the University of Hyderabad for IT parks, more than 50 bulldozers tore through green land over a holiday weekend, before an expert committee on forest land had even reported. On April 3, 2025, the Supreme Court stepped in on its own, called the destruction of 100 acres alarming, and told the state to restore the forest or see its officers, the Chief Secretary included, go to jail. When the highest court must threaten a Chief Secretary with prison, what credibility remains?

Lagacherla: In the Chief Minister's own constituency of Kodangal, his government moved to seize 1,358 acres for a pharma village, using Section 10A to skip the social impact assessment and public hearing. Farmers revolted. On November 29, 2024, the notification was withdrawn and the land rebranded as "Multipurpose Industrial Park". On March 6, 2025, the High Court stayed that too. If the Chief Minister cannot plan for his own constituency, what hope does the rest of Telangana have?

Musi: Estimates lurch between Rs 56,000 crore and Rs 1.5 lakh crore; the Gandhi Sarovar component jumped from Rs 5,000 to Rs 7,000 crore within days. Some 10,200 homes were marked for removal, and the homes of the poor fell before a DPR, or rehabilitation policy existed. Comparatively speaking, if cleaning the Ganga costs a 'mere' Rs 42,000 crore, why does 55 km of the Musi need Rs 1.5 lakh crore?

Future City: Glittering renderings, sweeping promises. But what exists on the ground?

Four projects. One script. No legislative debate, no expert opinion, no public hearing, no environmental study. Decision first, thinking later; then a court rebuke, a U-turn, and a bill handed to the people.

(The writer is a member of the Telangana Legislative Council)

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दैनिक जागरण, राजस्थान पत्रिका, दैनिक भास्कर, दिव्यभास्कर, हिंदुस्तान, नवभारत टाइम्स, बिजनस स्टंडर्ड, अमर उजाला, जनसत्ता, द पायोनीर, राष्ट्रीय सहारा, प्रभातखबर, लोकसत्ता

Others»»»

Hindi & English Editorial, Employment News, Malayalam Newspapers, Tamil, Telugu, Urdu, Gujarati

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Final verification for 46.63L flagged voters launched

• BLOs to make fresh house-to-house checks before final rolls on October 16

• Drive also to enrol eligible voters left out of SIR; inadvertent deletions can be restored through Form-6

HANS NEWS SERVICE
AMARAVATI

WITH the final electoral rolls under the Special Intensive Revision (SIR), 2026 scheduled to be published on October 16, the Election Commission has launched a special drive in Andhra Pradesh to re-verify 46.63 lakh electors flagged during the revision process and identify eligible voters who may have been left out.

Chief Electoral Officer and E O Vivek Yadav said Booth Level Officers (BLOs) would



begin fresh door-to-door verification from Thursday, carrying polling-station-wise lists of 46,62,583 deleted names. The exercise is aimed at ensuring that genuine voters are not inadvertently excluded while ineligible names remain out of the rolls.

During the enumeration phase from June 15 to July 24, BLOs conducted house-to-house verification and found 44,89,512 electors not available at their registered addresses due to death, permanent migration, multiple enrolments, untraceability

and other reasons. Following verification and removal of such entries, the draft electoral rolls published on July 31 contained 3,71,38,182 electors. The scrutiny did not end with the draft publication. During the subsequent notice phase, another

1,73,071 electors were found ineligible as on October 6 for inclusion in the final roll. The latest drive will specifically recheck the flagged cases. If an elector is found to have been deleted inadvertently, the BLOs will facilitate filing of Form-6, enabling restoration of the name after due verification through continuous updation.

The CEO said the exercise was part of the ECI's objective of ensuring that no eligible voter is left out while ineligible names are excluded.

The final SIR rolls will be published on October 16. However, voters who miss inclusion in the final roll will not lose the opportunity to register subsequently. The electoral system provides four qualifying dates- January 1, April 1, July 1 and October 1- and eligible persons can apply through Form-6 during continuous updation. The Annual Summary Revision is conducted with January 1 of the succeeding year as the qualifying date.

Health minister orders probe into copying incidents at Nandyal

Seeks report from medical and health secretary within a week on the alleged incident in Govt Medical College in Nandyal

HANS NEWS SERVICE
AMARAVATI

HEALTH minister Y Satya Kumar Yadav ordered a comprehensive inquiry into alleged copying incidents during examinations at the Government Medical College in Nandyal and directed the health and medical education department secretary to submit a detailed report within a week.

The minister took serious note of the incidents and sought details about the action taken by the college authorities and Dr NTR University of Health Sciences after an earlier copying incident came to light in August.

He directed officials to examine whether the first incident was properly investigat-

ed and whether timely and appropriate action was taken against those responsible. He also asked the department to identify any lapses in the handling of the matter.

The minister instructed the secretary to conduct a thorough inquiry into the circumstances that led to the copying incidents. The investigation should establish where lapses occurred in the conduct of examinations, how the incident took place and the method allegedly used for copying.

He also directed officials to examine whether there were any shortcomings in the manner in which officials of Dr NTR University of Health Sciences responded to the first incident.

The minister said the inquiry report should clearly identify the role of those responsible and recommend measures to prevent recurrence of such incidents in the future.

He emphasised that examination procedures in medical colleges must be conducted with utmost integrity and transparency, as any malpractice could have serious implications for the quality of medical education and healthcare delivery.

Governor launches 77th TB Seal sale campaign



Governor and TB Association of AP honorary president Justice S Abdul Nazeer launches the 77th TB Seal Sale Campaign at Lok Bhavan in Vijayawada on Wednesday

HANS NEWS SERVICE
VIJAYAWADA

GOVERNOR and honorary president of the TB Association of AP Justice S Abdul Nazeer launched the 77th TB Seal Sale Campaign at a programme held Lok Bhavan here on Wednesday.

Addressing the gathering, the Governor said that although 144 years had passed since Sir Robert Koch discovered the causative organism of tuberculosis (TB), the disease continued to claim lives despite significant advances in its prevention and

treatment.

He said TB was not merely a medical challenge but also a social and economic concern affecting individuals, families and communities. The fight against the disease, therefore, should go beyond treatment and focus on creating awareness, ensuring early diagnosis, prevention, adequate nutrition, social support and active community participation.

The Governor said the TB Mukta Bharat Abhiyaan, launched by the Central government, emphasised a whole-of-government and

whole-of-society approach to eliminate TB from the country ahead of the global Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) target of 2030 adopted by the United Nations.

He said the TB Seal Sale Campaign had special significance as it combined public awareness with public participation in the fight against tuberculosis. He appealed to citizens, educational institutions, industries, corporate houses, voluntary organisations and philanthropists to extend their support and contribute generously to the campaign.

Power staff families to get jobs within 4 months

• 27 kin of deceased APGenco staff get compassionate appointments

• Energy minister Ravi Kumar says 627 families given jobs since coalition govt came to power

• 7,000 energy assistants being trained to ease manpower shortage

HANS NEWS SERVICE
AMARAVATI

ENERGY minister Gottipati Ravi Kumar on Wednesday said the state government is committed to supporting the families of electricity department employees who lost their lives while on duty. He said the government has ended the long delays that once forced families to wait for years for compassionate appointments and is now issuing job orders to eligible family members within four months.

At a programme held at the Secretariat, the minister handed over compassionate appointment letters to 27 eligible family members of deceased employees who had served in APGenco. APGenco managing director S Nagalakshmi was also present at the event.

Ravi Kumar said that since the coalition government assumed office, compassionate



Energy minister Gottipati Ravi Kumar and APGenco managing director S Nagalakshmi hand over compassionate appointment letters to one of the beneficiaries at the Secretariat on Wednesday

appointment orders have been issued to 627 beneficiaries.

The initiative is aimed at providing livelihood security to families affected by the loss of earning members.

To address manpower shortages in the power sector, the minister said around 7,000 energy assistants are being trained and their services will be utilised.

He also noted that the government is filling 629 assistant engineer posts and is effectively dealing with legal challenges to the recruitment process. The minister stressed that the government has not increased electricity tariffs since coming to power. Under the leadership of Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu, the state is strengthening power utilities and investing heavily in infrastructure development.

As part of efforts to improve power supply quality, the government is constructing 132 kv, 220 kv and 400 kv substations in different

parts of the state. Additional 33/11 kv substations and distribution transformers are also being installed to address low-voltage issues and ensure uninterrupted electricity supply for domestic, agricultural, aquaculture, industrial and commercial consumers.

Ravi Kumar said the government is also prioritizing renewable energy.

Under the PM Surya Ghar scheme, steps are being taken to provide solar units to six lakh SC and ST families.

He added that Andhra Pradesh has emerged as one of the leading states in implementing the programme.

The minister advised newly recruited employees to undergo proper training and strictly follow safety protocols, emphasizing that safety and responsibility are crucial in the power sector.

He said the government will continue investing in strengthening the state's electricity system and improving consumer satisfaction.

Drumstick processing units to boost rural incomes

HANS NEWS SERVICE
AMARAVATI

THE state government is rolling out a drumstick (moringa) value-addition programme aimed at increasing farmers' incomes, strengthening Farmer Producer Organisations (FPOs), and creating local employment opportunities for rural women.

In a statement on Wednesday, minister for MSMEs, rural poverty alleviation and NRI Empowerment Kondapalli Srinivas said the initiative is being implemented through the Society for Elimination of Rural Poverty (SERP). The minister said the government has prepared a plan to establish 19 drumstick processing units across the state so that farmers are not limited to selling drumstick leaves alone but can also participate in processing, packaging, branding and marketing activities. The proposal has been developed based on the success of existing drumstick processing units at Veeraballi in YSR Kadapa district and Yerravaripalem in Tirupati district.

The locations for the new units are being identified based on local climatic conditions, cultivation area, farmers' interest, raw material availability and the capacity of FPOs. The government is also sourcing high-yielding quality seeds from the Horticultural College



A drumstick process unit at Yerravaripalem in Tirupati district

and Research Institute at Periyakulam in Tamil Nadu and distributing them to farmers. Special study tours have also been arranged to provide exposure to processing, quality control and marketing practices.

Srinivas said a processing plant established with livelihood funds in Yerravaripalem mandal is currently producing 250 kg of drumstick powder per day. According to the minister, the cost of producing one kilogram of drumstick leaves is around Rs 10, while FPOs purchase the produce from farmers at Rs 15 per kg, enabling farmers to earn a profit of Rs 5 per kg. The Yerravaripalem unit, set up at a cost of Rs 86.80 lakh, procures drumstick leaves from around 300 acres of cultivation.

TGSRTC to ply 7,000 special buses to clear Dasara rush

• Extra services on peak travel dates
• 1,312 buses from Greater Hyderabad
• 3,533 buses from Karimnagar zone
• Higher fares on special buses
• Regular bus fares unchanged
• Free travel for women continues
• Return rush services on Oct 25 and 26
• Advance booking advised

HANS NEWS SERVICE
HYDERABAD

THE Telangana State Road Transport Corporation (TGSRTC) has made elaborate arrangements by operating over 7,000 special buses across Telangana and to neighbouring states to meet the expected surge in passenger demand during the Dasara festival.

According to TGSRTC, of these, as many as 3,533 special buses will be operated from the Karimnagar zone. Region-wise, the services include 431 buses from Adilabad, 719 from Nizamabad, 1,175 from Karimnagar, 530 from Warangal and 678 from Khammam.

The Hyderabad Zone will operate 2,155 special buses, including 645 from Mahbub-

nagar, 255 from Medak, 815 from Nalgonda and 440 from Rangareddy.

In addition, the Greater Hyderabad Zone will operate 1,312 special services during the festival.

TGSRTC Managing Director Y Nagi Reddy said that the corporation expects heavy passenger demand on October 9, 10, 16 and 17, and has planned to deploy additional buses depending on the rush. Special arrangements have also been made to handle the return journey rush expected on October 25 and 26. "In Hyderabad, special buses will operate from major passenger hubs, including MGBS, JBS, Uppal, Aramghar, LB Nagar Cross Roads, KPHB, Bowenpally and Gachibowli," Nagi Reddy added.



For the convenience of passengers, the corporation will arrange tents, chairs, public address systems, drinking water facilities and mobile toilets at key locations. Nagi Reddy clarified that free bus travel for women under the Telangana government's Mahalakshmi scheme will continue as usual on Dasara services.

Furthermore, the Managing Director said that TGSRTC has also revised fares for the Dasara special buses in accordance with a 2003

state government order (GO No. 16). The order permits the corporation to revise fares by up to 1.5 times on special services operated during festivals and other special occasions to cover additional diesel and operational costs.

The revised fares will apply only to special buses operating within Telangana and to other states. They will be applicable on October 9, 10, 16 and 17, as well as October 25 and 26, when return journey demand is expected

to be high. Regular fares will continue to apply on regular bus services, and the revised fares will not apply to regular buses. The facility will be available on Pale Velugu, Express, City Ordinary and Metro Express regular and special buses.

TGSRTC has advised passengers to make advance reservations through its official booking website, www.tgsrtc.in and can also contact at 040-69440000 or 040-23450033 for bus services.

Revenue officials take up re-survey of farm lands

ESA BIN ABDUL REHMAN
RANGAREDDY

AS part of the exercise to dispel apprehensions of the farmers regarding the boundaries of their farm lands, the revenue officials in Rangareddy district on Wednesday took up re-survey of lands in Imamguds village in Maheshwaram mandal. District Collector C Narayana Reddy accompanied by the Additional Collector (Revenue) K Chandra Reddy supervised the re-survey programme assisted by Maheshwaram tahsildar, mandal surveyor and licensed surveyors on the field.

NORTHERN RAILWAY		
TENDER NOTICE		
The Dy. Chief Electrical Engineer/Const./Northern Railway, DRM Office, New Delhi-110001 invites EPC-tender under Single stage Two Packet System for the under noted work:-		
1	Name of work and location	"Design, Supply, Erection, Testing, Commissioning of Laying of Cable for the connection of SP/SSP/ In NDLS-CPYZ Section of Delhi Division of Northern Railway for raising of speed to 160 Kmph.
2	Completion period of the work	12 Months
3	Approx. Cost of work	Rs. 94,15,93,660.90/-
4	Bid Security amount (to be deposited online as given in Tender)	Rs. 1,88,31,900/-
5	Date & Time of opening of tender	Tenders will be opened on or after 11.00 hrs on date 11.11.2026 on IREPS web site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in . The bidders can participate in the epc-tender.
6	Detailed Tender Notice & Tender Document	The detailed e-tender notice and tender document is available on www.ireps.gov.in . Above tender document will be available for submission of offer on IREPS web site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in from 08.10.2026 to 03.11.2026. All other terms and conditions in respect of above tenders are given in tender document. The detailed tender notice also can be seen on the Notice Board of the above office.
Tender No.: 347/Dy.CEE/C/NDLS/2026-27/EPC Dated: 07.10.2026 3482/2026		
SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE		

NORTHERN RAILWAY TENDER NOTICE				
Invitation of tender through E-Tendering (E-Procurement Systems)				
S. No.	Name of work with its location	Approx. cost of work	EMD amount	Completion period of work
(A)	Improvement to damaged protective walls, plastering/grills, kerb stones, open drain covering, lawn flooring, outside plastering, outside painting etc. at S.P Marg Railway Officers Enclave in the s/o SSE/W/SP Marg under ADENE-III.	Rs. 19999413.66	Rs. 400000.00	09 Months
(B)	Repair & Renovation work of vacant Type V & Type VI duplex at San Martin Marg and Railway Board members Bungalows at Meti Bagh and other allied work in the S/o SSE/W/SP Marg under ADENE-III.	Rs. 16999459.41	Rs. 340000.00	09 Months
Date and Time for Opening & Closing date of tender on 03.11.2026 at 15:00 hrs.				
Website particular notice board location complete details of tender can be seen and address of the office from where the tender form can be purchased etc.				
Above tender available on website i.e. http://www.ireps.gov.in				
No: 128-W/269/O.E./T/NIT No. 22 (A,B)/26-27/WE/ Dated:- 05.10.2026 3468/2026				
SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE				



History would be kinder to outgoing chairman of selectors Ajit Agarkar whose conviction in "team first" was crucial to the country winning three ICC trophies during his tenure. Thank you for everything. My heartfelt wishes for your future endeavours!
-Gautam Gambhir

'Rising Together' is India's vision for 2036 Olympic bid

NEW DELHI

SPORTS Minister Mansukh Mandaviya and Indian Olympic Association President P T Usha on Wednesday said that the country's bid to host the 2036 Olympics will revolve around the vision of "Rising Together" and the first project presentation to the IOC's Future Host Commission will be

Hosting the Olympic and Paralympic Games would inspire millions of young Indians to participate in sport, strengthen healthier and more active communities, and create new opportunities for our youth across education, employment and social development: Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya



made at the end of November.

The International Olympic Committee (IOC) said India, Germany, Qatar and Turkiye

are among seven countries with a stated interest in hosting the 2036 Olympics and have been invited to present their

Games projects to the IOC's Future Host Commission next month. "India's ambition for 2036 is rooted in a simple idea:

that sport can help shape the future of our nation.

Hosting the Olympic and Paralympic Games would inspire millions of young Indians to participate in sport, strengthen healthier and more active communities, and create new opportunities for our youth across education, employment and social development," stated Mandaviya in

a press release issued by the IOA. Ahmedabad is India's city of choice to host the quadrennial showpiece, which has never been held in the country before. India submitted its Expression of Interest to host the Games in 2024.

Usha said the IOA feels deeply honoured by the IOC's recognition of India's aspirations. "...proud to be part of an

exceptional group of potential hosts for future editions of the Games," she said. "For us, 'Rising Together' is not simply a slogan -- it is a powerful commitment to unite India's energy, ambition and diversity behind a shared Olympic dream. "As we develop our vision for 2036, we want to create a Games that reflects the confidence of a young, dy-

namic and rising India, while contributing to the Olympic and Paralympic Movements' ambition to reach new generations, new communities and new horizons around the world. "We look forward to continuing our exchange with the IOC and to present our ambition to the Future Host Commission for the first time at the end of November," she added in a revised statement issued by the IOA after earlier stating that the month of presentation would be October.

Argentina bids Messi farewell

It feels like an era is ending, knowing he won't play for the national team anymore, says fan

BUENOS AIRES

ARGENTINA is confronting a once-unimaginable reality: a national team without soccer great Lionel Messi. The 39-year-old Messi bid farewell to international soccer after 21 years, 126 goals, two Copa America titles and a World Cup championship, scoring a penalty and setting up Argentina's other two goals for a 3-0 victory over Benin. What was otherwise an unremarkable friendly against the West African nation became a moment that this soccer-crazed country had long dreaded.

"It feels like an era is ending, knowing he won't play for the national team anymore," said Valentino Ruso, who was heading to a friend's house in Buenos Aires to

watch the game. "I'm sad. I think everyone is upset today. He will be missed."

Argentines had an intense, often unforgiving relationship with the shy boy who left his hometown of Rosario at 13 for the youth academy of Spanish club Barcelona. As he grew into a global icon of near-mythical stature, his compatriots adored and abused him,

sometimes questioning his commitment to his home country and accusing him of indifference to it. But by the time he ended his dazzling international career, his devotion to Argentina was no longer in question. Nor was Argentina's devotion to its most famous export, whose triumphs reminded the country of its capacity for greatness through years of political and economic instability.

"Argentines often say, Thank God I was born at a time when I could experience the miracle of watching Messi play," said Andres Rabinovich, a University of Chicago scholar who has researched soccer's role in Argentine culture.

"It's hard living in Argentina. Soccer is often one of the few things that offers you some respite, some joy."



Iyer's century signals his top form: Gavaskar

Rises to career-best 7th in T20I rankings; Gill consolidates No.1 position in ODI list

LUCKNOW: Shreyas Iyer's maiden T20I hundred came at an "important time", signalling that the Indian skipper is back to his best after having a torrid time with the bat," said Sunil Gavaskar. Iyer had managed to breach the 50-run mark only twice since taking over as India's T20 captain in June. However, he struck an unbeaten 102 in the opening game against the West Indies to power India to an eight-wicket win.

"It was a sublime knock from Shreyas Iyer. He looked unstoppable, and no matter what lines and lengths the West Indian bowlers bowled, Iyer had an answer to everything. "Shreyas Iyer has had a bit of a torrid time with the bat since becoming the captain of this Indian T20I squad. In recent times, the wins have come, but his own form with the bat was a concern. "So, it was important for him to play a big knock, and he delivered in this first T20I," Gavaskar said on JioStar.



Iyer climbed to a career-best seventh spot in the latest ICC rankings for the shortest format, while ODI skipper Shubman Gill retained the top position in the 50-over batting list. The explosive innings has lifted Iyer 18 places, making him India's third-highest ranked batter in the format. Ishan Kishan and Abhishek Sharma continue to occupy the top two spots with Tilak Varma at 10th, giving India four batters in the top 10, stated an ICC release. Teen sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi has climbed eight places to 46th.

Baloda's 8/41 powers India U-19 to a crushing 10-wicket win over Oz

AHMEDABAD: Left-arm orthodox spinner Tanmay Baloda returned 8/41 to complete an impressive 14-wicket match haul as India U-19 crushed Australia by 10 wickets on day three of the second Youth Test, winning the series 2-0 here on Wednesday.

Australia were shot out for a mere 151 after resuming at 86 for four on the third day, setting India only 11 runs to win, which the hosts achieved without losing a wicket. India had earlier posted 315 in their only innings, taking a lead of 141 runs after bundling

Australia out for 174 in their first innings. Lakshya Raichandani cracked two fours off Spencer Green to help India achieve the target only five balls into the first over, recording a comprehensive win here at the B Ground of the Narendra Modi Stadium. The Indian U-19 side was ruthless in their approach to claim the series 2-0, having earlier won the first Youth Test by an innings and 48 runs in Rajkot. Before that, India U-19 had claimed a commanding 3-0 win in the Youth ODI series, which preceded the Tests.



Baloda was the star performer of the second Youth Test as the Haryana spinner returned 6/32 and 8/41 in the two innings.

Brief scores: Australia U-19 174 & 151 in 43.5 overs (Eli Brain 39, Blake Cattle 63; Tanmay Baloda 8/41, Priyanshu Singh 2/25) lost to India U-19 315 & 11/0 in 0.5 overs (Lakshya Raichandani 9 not out) by 10 wickets.

IGPL and HGA eye vibrant golf presence in Hyd

HANS NEW SERVICE HYDERABAD

THE Krishna Invitational 2026 Am Green IGPL, marking the AM Green IGPL's Season 2, took off on an exciting note at the Hyderabad Golf Club (HGC) here on Wednesday.

Being hosted by Krishna Punjab Raptors GC, the four-day championship will culminate on October 10.

Meanwhile, the Hyderabad Golf Association (HGA) is hoping to ride on the tournament's success to bring more professional golf events to Hyderabad.

Speaking at the inaugural, HGA President, Bhaskar Reddy, said "We are proud



(From left) Manav Jaini, Director Bharath Golf Private Limited, Uttam Singh Mundy, CEO IGPL, Bhaskar Reddy, P Hemanth Reddy and Sandeep Rathi (all from HGA), unveiling the coveted trophy at HGC in Hyderabad on Wednesday

to host IGPL's first leg in Hyderabad. We want IGPL to not only bring their tour to our course but also more professional events. We will be happy to host them," and

added "We have added two more holes to the heritage course."

"Our association with HGA began in 2024 by sponsoring the Telangana Golconda Masters. It is good to be back," recalled Uttam Singh Mundy, CEO, AM Green IGPL.

Mundy said, "Every successful tour gives its players a route to a higher level, and the AM Green IGPL professionals already have a pathway with the Asian Tour and building professional opportunities for school and young golfing students." Sandeep Rathi, Committee member, HGA, and P Hemanth Reddy, HGA Course Chairman, also spoke on the occasion.

Four students die while cleaning school water tank

MATHURA

FOUR Students died and another fell unconscious after they entered a water tank to clean it at a residential school in Vrindavan, police said on Wednesday. The incident took place at Vrindavan Gurukulam.

The students entered the

tank after noticing a foul smell emanating from it. Mathura Senior Superintendent of Police (SSP) Shlok Kumar said one student first entered the tank to clean it but did not come out. After that, four other students went inside the tank. When they too did not emerge, people present there pulled them out.

The students were rushed to a hospital, where four of them were declared dead. Those killed were identified as Manu Katara (24), a resident of Jabalpur district of Madhya Pradesh; Rishabh Sharma (18) from Meerut; Aryan Sharma (18) from Kaushambi and Devansh (17) from Vidhisha district

of Madhya Pradesh.

Dr. Vinit Yadav Medical Superintendent of the local hospital here said that the fifth boy, Rudra Videsh (18) is stable and recovering. District magistrate Chandra Prakash Singh has ordered an inquiry into the incident by the city magistrate. Police are examining CCTV

footage from the premises to ascertain the sequence of events. "Further legal action will be taken after receiving a complaint from the families," Kumar said, adding the bodies have been sent for postmortem and efforts are underway to contact their families. Around 200 students are learning Sanskrit at

the school and at present 100 students are residing inside the campus. Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath expressed grief over the loss of lives in the incident. In a post on X, the chief minister described the incident as "extremely sad and heartbreaking" and conveyed his condolences to the bereaved families.



West Bengal to be renamed Paschim Banga: State BJP

KOLKATA: West Bengal Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) president Samik Bhattacharya on Wednesday indicated that the state's name will likely be changed to 'Paschim Banga', asserting preservation of the land's historical identity. Speaking to reporters, Bhattacharya firmly said, "How many times must I say, brother? The name will be 'Paschim Banga'."

Earlier on Monday, the state BJP chief had asserted that alternative nomenclature would be done away with, stating that the formal transition to 'Paschim Banga' was imminent.

"Yes, absolutely. Paschim Banga Bhavan... West Bengal's 'Paschim...' For a long time now, you will no longer have to hear names like 'Paschim Bangla', 'Bangla', or 'Bangal'. 'Paschim Banga' (West Bengal) is coming," Bhattacharya had told reporters.

Announcing that a legislative bill will soon be introduced to anchor the state's identity to its history, he fur-



ther said, "Very soon, in the very first session itself, our government is introducing a bill so that the name of this state remains intrinsically linked with the history of this state, and that remains its identity. That is why the state is going to be named 'Paschim Banga'."

Beyond the renaming issue, Bhattacharya also spoke on a wide range of political and policy matters, hailing Prime Minister Narendra Modi's address marking his 25 years as head of government.

3 tennis players die in accident

SULTANPUR: Three tennis players were killed and an equal injured when the car they were in rammed into a truck's behind on the Purvanchal Expressway here on Wednesday, police said.

The accident took place around 5.30 am near Sukhabaderi in the Dhanpatganj Police Station area, when the allegedly speeding Maruti Suzuki Ertiga carrying the six players crashed into the rear of the truck, they said.

The players were returning to Deoria after participating in a sporting event in Lucknow. According to pre-



liminary information, the car was speeding at around 100 kmph. The impact left the car mangled, trapping the occupants inside. Police, with the help of locals, broke open the doors and extricated them. All six were taken to a nearby hospital, where doctors declared three of them dead, the police said. The deceased were identified as Nitya Pra-

japati and Irfan Ansari, aged 22 and 20 and both from Deoria, and Aniket, a 24-year-old resident of Bhagalpur.

The injured were identified as Anand Yadav, 23, and Raju, 22, and Jayanto Sharma, 30, a resident of Birbhum in West Bengal. They were referred to Ayodhya Medical College for further treatment, the police said. Sharma told the police that most of the car occupants were asleep and were jolted awake by the collision. The truck driver sped away after the accident and is being looked for, the police said.

Virat Kohli denies he took money to visit Premanand's ashram

NEW DELHI: A spokesperson of Virat Kohli on Wednesday rejected allegations that the Indian batting stalwart was paid for his first visit to the ashram of spiritual leader Premanand Maharaj, calling them "completely false, and baseless." Kohli and his actor wife Anushka Sharma are devotees of Premanand Maharaj and have made several visits to his ashram in Vrindavan.

However, Falahari Maharaj recently alleged that Kohli received Rs 5 crore for his first visit to the ashram in



2023. "We would like to categorically state that the claims made by Falahari Maharaj Dinesh Sharma in regards to Mr. Virat Kohli are completely false, baseless and factually incorrect," Kohli's spokesperson said in a statement. The spokesperson said

Kohli's visits to the ashram were motivated by "deep faith and reverence for Maharaj Ji." "We strongly refute these claims and urge the media to exercise due diligence, verify facts before reporting or amplifying such statements, and report responsibly," the statement added. Kohli's visits to the Premanand Maharaj's ashram have continued through significant moments in his career, including after his Test retirement in 2025.

Their most recently reported visit came in July this year.



10 schools in Guj get bomb threats

AHMEDABAD: Ten private schools in Ahmedabad received bomb threat emails on Wednesday, triggering security checks which later confirmed the threats were a hoax, officials said. The sender of the email claimed to be associated with the "Khalistan National Army" and also warned of bomb blasts at JLN (Jawahar Lal Nehru) Stadium in Delhi on November 1 and Narendra Modi Stadium in Ahmedabad on November 21, sources said.

The two dates coincide with scheduled concerts of singer Diljit Dosanjh at the respective venues. The email also warned people against attending Dosanjh's concerts at the two venues, the sources said.

After being alerted, police, along with bomb detection and disposal squads, dog squads and anti-sabotage teams, reached the schools and conducted thorough searches. Nothing suspicious was found at any of the establishments, the officials said.

Deputy Commissioner of Police, Zone 7, Shivam Verma said, "In the email sent to nearly 10 schools, it was claimed that bomb blasts will be carried out in these establishments today morning. Our teams reached these schools and conducted a thorough search.

HC: Students protesting exam malpractices not anti-social



MUMBAI: The Bombay High Court on Wednesday said the students protesting against alleged malpractices in the MPSC examinations are not anti-social elements, and stressed that the state government was duty-bound to ensure that public recruitment exams are conducted impartially.

A bench of Chief Justice Mahesh Chandra Tripathi and Justice Advait Sethna noted that the government has to give an assurance that whenever examinations are conducted, they are "impartial, fair and without any malpractices."

The court was hearing a petition filed by residents of Pune against the ongoing agitations in that city by students and others over alleged malpractices in the Maharashtra Public Service Commission (MPSC) exams and examination-related controversies. The government has to ensure sincere effort in restoring the trust of people, especially students in such exams, the bench said. It

further said that aggrieved students have a right to agitate. "If they (students) do not have an opportunity and they get the idea that there has been hanky panky, they have the right to agitate. Because they have given hours of study," the court said.

Advocate General Milind Sathe, appearing for the state government, said the authorities have been showing reasonable restraint and have not lodged any FIRs against any protesters. He further said that most of the demands raised by the protesters have been met. "One of their demands was the resignation of the MPSC Chairman. A recommendation has been sent to the Governor as per the procedure and further action is awaited," Sathe said. Appreciating the government's move of not lodging any case against the agitators, the court said, "The protesters are students. They are not anti-social elements."



Hosting 'The Traitors' Telugu is like watching a mystery thriller: Teja Sajja

Teja Sajja is all set to host the regional version of the reality show, 'The Traitors'. The show, which has been made by SOL Production, will be available only on Prime Video in Telugu with English subtitles from October 15. The episodes of the show will go live every Thursday at noon.

The reality show, which will have 20 celebrities from various fields, will witness 10 episodes with trust and betrayal as the main theme.

At a press conference, Teja Sajja said he had fun hosting the show and even compared the format to a murder mystery thriller.

The actor shared that he shot for 11 days for the show and was ecstatic to see familiar faces like Pragathi, Harshavardhan and Chinmayi play the game. "It was a challenge to host as I had to give long speeches about rules and regulations in one take while getting into the minds of the game," he added.

The actor claimed that 'The Traitors' Telugu is something different in terms of reality shows in Telugu. "It is similar to a sport like football or chess where a person needs to know the rules, understand, strategise and outsmart the opponent," he said.

Teja Sajja added that the reality show has picked up celebrities based on their game-playing skills and not because of their status. "It will be more entertaining for all age groups," he said.

'Comrade Kalyan' uses Sree Vishnu's full potential as an entertainer: Director Janakiram Marella

Director Janakiram Marella believes his upcoming period entertainer, 'Comrade Kalyan', would deliver the audiences with sheer entertainment as Sree Vishnu has utilized his acting skills to full potential as the lead actor. The movie, which also has ample portions of romance and emotions, is all set to release globally on 9th October.

While talking about the film, director Janakiram Marella disclosed that the name 'Comrade Kalyan' was derived from the story itself. He expressed that Sree Vishnu's caliber as an entertainer has been utilized in full potential in the film as the actor has played a hilarious role which eventually



lands him in trouble.

The director further stated that they faced several difficulties while shooting in the dense forests of Agumbe in Mangaluru, known for its wilderness and snakes. He added that they go to great lengths to make the film realistic and entertaining.

The filmmaker especially thanked Sree Vishnu for being a supportive co-star and doing the difficult tasks

for the film. He stated the actor had hiked three kms for the shoot and also did a lot of improvisation which helped the film become an entertainer.

Apart from Sree Vishnu, Mahima Nambiar plays the leading lady as the film revolves around the love chemistry between the lead pair. Radhika Sarathkumar, Sathya, and Shine Tom Jacob also play crucial roles.

Comrade Kalyan, presented by Kona Venkat and produced by Venkata Krishna Karnati and Seetha Karnati under Skanda Vahana Motion Pictures LLP, features four different flavored music tracks that have fetched good responses from the audience.

Manoj Manchu visits Chamundeshwari temple in Mysuru

Actor Manoj Manchu and his wife Bhuma Mounika Manchu and their kids Dhairav and Devasena Shobha visited the Sri Chamundeshwari temple on the top of Chamundi hills in Mysuru to seek the blessings of the deity.

The actor duo was welcomed by the temple priests in a traditional Poornakumbham and performed special poojas and rituals. They also received the Vedic blessings from the scholars and later received the Seshavastaram and Theertha Prasadam from the priests. Manoj Manchu who is currently



shooting for the high-octane action film 'Daada' starring Nandamuri Balakrishna and directed

by Gopichand Malineni, visited the temple which has become the location for the actor's crucial role

in the film. The actor's visit to the temple has created quite an impression on the devotees and his fans.

'Hanuman Ansh' team banks on strong connect with Telugu audiences

Spiritual drama Hanuman Ansh, based on the life and preach of revered guru Neem Karoli Baba, is all set to hit the Telugu screens on October 9. The film, which had grossed heavily in Hindi, is all set to release in South India by Hombale Films through their overseas division.

Written and directed by Dr. Vishal Chaturvedi, Hanuman Ansh stars Shobhinav Satya as Neem Karoli Baba with Chandan Anand and Purnima Tiwari in pivotal roles. The film revolves around faith, devotion, and spirituality.

Shobhinav Satya said in the Hyderabad press meet



that the film reflects Indian culture, and expressed confidence that the Telugu audience would resonate with the film, saying that Hanuman's blessings have brought it to fruition so far.

Director Vishal Chatur-

vedi said he was elated to take the film to the Telugu audience as devotion to Lord Hanuman was visible everywhere in Andhra Pradesh and Telangana states. Producer Ragini thanked Hombale Films for taking

on board the Telugu release. Mythri Movie Makers producer Ravi Shankar appreciated the film and the performance of Shobhinav Satya. Shashidhar Reddy said that the film delivers a message for families.

'Saripoyaru Iddaroo' teaser promises a fun-filled family entertainer

National award-winning filmmaker Vegesna Satish, who has given us wholesome family entertainers like Shatamanam Bhavathi, is back with another exciting film Saripoyaru Iddaroo. The film stars young heroes Meghamsh Sri Hari and Yashwin Vegesna in the lead roles while Riddhi Kumar and Megha Chowdhury play the female leads. The veteran actors Dr. Rajendra Prasad and V.K. Naresh also play important roles in the film.

Today, blockbuster director Anil Ravipudi unveiled the exciting teaser of Saripoyaru Iddaroo, which promises to be an entertaining family drama with full of rivalry, romance, drama, and more.

The teaser starts with a fight between the two young heroes who seem to be enemies. They are completely opposite to each other and have a strange but fascinat-



ing relationship with each other. It seems that the entire story revolves around these rival pairs. The majority of the teasers are made up of young actors who engage in a large-scale fight.

Although the teaser showcases various other aspects of the film, the romance track between the young pair appears to be a complete entertainer.

Sameer Reddy's camera adds vibrancy to the film, while Anup Rubens's music

keeps us engaged throughout the teaser. Ramanjaneyulu has done wonderful work with the film's production design, whereas Madhu has given incredible energy to the editing department.

Produced by Sadath and Muni Shiva under Happy Ox Entertainment, MS Varahi Creations, and Satamaan-ambhavati Arts, the film appears to be a wholesome entertainer that promises to provide exciting family entertainment.

'Cheekato Vaipuna' from 'Maya Lady' unveiled

Young singer and producer Rakesh Varre has released a melodious song titled 'Cheekato Vaipuna' from his upcoming film Maya Lady. Directed by Prasankar, Maya Lady features Rakesh Varre as the lead hero and Madhumita Sarcas as the heroine. The film will be launched in theatres soon.

The film Maya Lady, which is a Crazy Ants Production, will be the latest venture of young producer Rakesh Varre, who has in the past bankrolled content films like Evvarikee Cheppoddu and Pekamedalu. The film's song 'Cheekato Vaipuna' is a soulful number, which narrates the anguish and pain

of a jilted lover. It beautifully captures the dilemma, hope and dejection of the lover in the lyrics and has a sad tune to it. The song's music has been composed by Vishal Chandrashekar while Krishna Kanth has penned the lyrics. Besides, the music composer and lyricist duo, the track witnesses powerful voices of Yazin Nizar and Sindhu Vishal. With the powerful renderings of the singers and the sad tune and lyrics, the song has become an important pre-release track for the film. Besides, the song has also created enough curiosity about the film's story as the song's lyrics narrate a sad tale of a jilted lover.



'Haiku' trailer offers a refreshing dose of romance and fun

The trailer is all set for the viewers as the producers unveil the romantic comedy 'Haiku' starring Aegan, Sridevi and Femina George on the occasion of its worldwide theatrical release on October 23. Written and directed by Yuvaraj Chinnaswamy, the movie is produced by Dr. D. Arulanandhu and Mathewo Arulanandhu under Vision Cinema House.

The 145 seconds trailer shows a breezy college setting and the story revolves around Mano, the only male

in a women's college. The quirky premise promises to deliver hilarious moments, romance and heart-warming episodes. The peek into the story is more of a feel-good rom-com with a message.

"It is a light hearted rom-com with a message. The movie talks about the alternate way of looking at men and women and how they have to stand by their choice and respect their counterparts in love and life," says Aegan.

Sridevi who stunned the audience with her role in

'Court: State Vs Nobody' delivers a natural performance and so does Femina George, adding spice to the romance. The other members in the ensemble cast include Adirchi Arun, Subramaniya Sethu, Adhiyaman, Mime Gopi and Indhumathi Manigandan.

Siddhu Kumar has composed the music while Priyesh Gurusamy has captured the visuals and Sakthi Praneesh P has edited the film. B. Sakthivelan of Sakthi Film Factory is releasing the film in Tamil Nadu.

'Mayookha' seems to be a fresh and engaging thriller

Director Shree Tej S.K. is all set to witness the global theatrical release of the thriller, 'Mayookha', starring Payal Chengappa. Produced by Sasidhar Nalla of Prashvitha Entertainment, the movie is all set to release on the 9th of this month.

The filmmaker spoke about how the film has been appreciated at various international fests even before its release. It has won the Best Mystery Movie at the New York film fest and the film also bagged the Second Best award in Thriller category. The team has also applied for Cannes film festival.

The filmmaker said that the film is inspired by Korean and Hollywood style of narration and visuals especially in terms of color grading. He asserted that



the screenplay in the film is a new take on thrillers, where the mystery deepens and unravels only in the second half. The movie also sees the hero in a new avatar, said Shree Tej.

The film stars Payal Chengappa, who has done several Kannada movies

and some Telugu web content. The filmmaker asserted that the audiences would connect to the character and her performance. The film is not a horror movie; it's a thriller where an unknown man walks into the heroine's flat and the mysteries around him are unveiled, he clarified.

Besides being a director, Shree Tej, who was earlier known as Srikanth Kandragula, is also a producer with Cinema Bandi productions. He has done a course in New York Film Academy and has been in the industry for almost two decades now.

His next project as a director would be an emotional science-fiction film, which would be a clean U-certified film, he concluded.



Aditi Rao flashes versatile fashion looks

Aditi Rao Hydari has showcased her versatility as an actress with a new set of pictures, as she flaunted three different glamorous looks for the latest issue of Femina. She begins by striking a pose in a champagne-hued beaded dress with a scooped neckline and thigh-high slit. In the next, she swaps into a sheer black lace mini with a fringe peplum and ruffled shoulders and ends on a strapless colour-block mini in lime green, red and navy. Aditi completes the looks with varying hairstyles, including a bun, wavy tresses and tousled bangs. The star has been hailed as a leading light in Hindi, Tamil and Telugu cinema for her work in Delhi 6, Padmaavat and Heeramandi, as well as the recent Lust Stories 3 opposite her husband Siddharth. Upcoming projects will see her take on O Saathi Re for Netflix, directed by Imtiaz Ali, and Welcome to Khoya Mahal.